

Social Psychology

1. What is social psychology

Human life, in fact, is connected by thousands of invisible threads. The places that people live, the situations they meet are all continuously and consistently shape them as well as get shaped by them. The situations an individual meet creates a good number of possibilities for him to behave. Social psychology is a specific branch in psychology that scientifically tries to understand how people influence as well as gets influenced by on other. It is a systematic body of knowledge focusing on the social thinking, social influence and social relations. A fundamental theme of social psychology is to discover how a social situation leads very different people to act very similarly. As well as how very similar people act very differently. Social Psychology is a scientific discipline. It is deeply committed to understand the nature of social behavior and social thought. For this reason it makes sense to describe the field as a scientific in orientation.

Why is it important to study Social Beh?

Aristotle: " Man is a Social animal and Cannot live in Vacuum" Social psychology studies social interaction and social processes. Social Interaction: General process in which two or more individuals are in a meaningful contact due to which their beh is modified however slightly. Social Processes: Forms of social interactions that occur repeatedly. 4 social processes: 1.Cooperation 2.Conflict 3. Competition 4.Accommodation.

Definition of Social Psychology

social psychology can be comprehensively defined as, a discipline that uses scientific methods in —an attempt to understand and explain how the thought, feeling and behaviour of individuals are influenced by the actual, imagined or implied presence of others (Gordon Allport, 1985, p. 3).

Social psychology is the scientific study of how individuals think, feel, and behave toward other people and how individual's thoughts, feelings, & behaviors are affected by other people (Brehm, Kassir, & Fein, 2002, p. 5).

What Questions Does Social Psychology Answer?

The major question social psychologists ponder is this: How and why are people's perceptions and actions influenced by environmental factors, such as social interaction?

In seeking the answer to that basic question, researchers conduct empirical studies to answer specific questions such as:

- How do individuals alter their thoughts and decisions based on social interactions?
- Is human behavior an accurate indication of personality?
- How goal oriented is social behavior?
- How does social perception influence behavior?
- How do potentially destructive social attitudes, such as prejudice, form?

Social Psychology Examples

What social psychology is focused on is studying changes over time. Social psychology research has touched on nearly every facet of human personality in an attempt to understand the psychological

influence of perception and human interaction. Of the topics currently being researched in social psychology, examples include:

- **Leadership** — What personality traits define a leader? What is the role of a leader within a group? How do leaders exercise influence on groups and individuals?
 - **Aggression** — How is aggressive behavior defined? What triggers habitual aggressive behavior? What role does aggression play in self-preservation?
 - **Social perception** — How does an individual develop self-perception? How is self-perception shaped by environmental factors? What is the difference between the existential self and the categorical self?
 - **Group behavior** — What characteristics do groups share? How many people constitute a group? What dictates the structure of a group? Why do individuals gravitate to a particular group?
 - **Nonverbal behavior** — What nonlinguistic actions communicate thought or meaning? How are nonverbal cues developed and interpreted? What emotions do facial expressions, hand gestures, and other nonverbal behaviors communicate?
 - **Conformity** — What prompts individuals to change their perceptions to match that of a group or another person? How does an individual decide to accept influence from another or a group? What is the difference between outward conformity and internal conformity?
 - **Prejudice** — What causes someone to harbor prejudice against a member of a different social group? What is the difference between prejudice and discrimination? How are stereotypes used to build perceptions?
- **Discuss the nature and concept of social psychology**
Social psychology is a scientific discipline that seeks to understand how individuals' thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are influenced by the presence of others.
 - It examines the social interactions and relationships that shape human behavior, with a particular focus on how social factors impact individuals' perceptions, attitudes, and actions. The field of social psychology recognizes the powerful influence of social context on human behavior, and it explores various processes and phenomena that occur within social groups.
 - At its core, social psychology investigates how people perceive, interpret, and respond to others. It examines how individuals form impressions of others, make attributions for their behavior, and navigate the complexities of social interactions. Social psychologists study a wide range of topics, including conformity, obedience, persuasion, prejudice, stereotypes, group dynamics, aggression, attraction, and altruism, among others. By exploring these phenomena, social psychology provides valuable insights into human behavior and helps us better understand the complexities of social life.
 - One fundamental concept in social psychology is the idea that individuals are not isolated entities but are deeply embedded in a social context. People are social creatures, and their thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are profoundly shaped by their interactions with others. Social psychologists recognize that social situations exert a significant influence on individuals, often leading to changes in behavior that may not occur in isolation. For example, people tend to conform to social norms, adjust their behavior to fit in with a group, and be influenced by the opinions and actions of others.
 - Another key concept in social psychology is the notion of social cognition, which refers to how individuals think about and interpret social information. Social cognition encompasses the mental processes involved in perceiving, processing, storing, and retrieving social information. It examines how individuals form judgments and make decisions based on social cues and how they construct and maintain their self-identity in relation to others. Social cognition also encompasses the study of attitudes, stereotypes, and the impact of social categorization on perception and behavior.

- One significant area of study within social psychology is the examination of social influence. Social influence refers to the ways in which individuals' thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are influenced by others. This includes the study of conformity, obedience, and compliance, which explores how individuals adjust their behavior to match that of others or to adhere to societal norms. Social influence can also be seen in the study of persuasion, which investigates the factors that make messages more persuasive and the techniques used to change attitudes and behavior.
- Another important concept within social psychology is the understanding of stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination. Stereotypes are simplified and generalized beliefs about social groups, while prejudice refers to negative attitudes and emotions directed towards individuals based on their group membership. Discrimination involves differential treatment of individuals based on their group membership. Social psychologists study these phenomena to gain insight into the causes and consequences of prejudice and discrimination and to develop strategies to reduce their harmful effects.
- Group dynamics is another central focus in social psychology. Groups play a crucial role in people's lives, and social psychologists investigate how groups form, function, and influence individuals. Group dynamics research explores topics such as leadership, conformity, decision-making processes, and intergroup relations. It examines how group membership shapes individuals' behavior, attitudes, and identity and how social identity processes can lead to intergroup conflict or cooperation.
- Additionally, social psychology investigates prosocial behavior, altruism, and aggression. Prosocial behavior refers to acts of helping, cooperation, and generosity, while altruism refers to selfless acts performed for the benefit of others. Social psychologists explore the factors that promote prosocial behavior and examine the conditions under which individuals are more likely to help others. Aggression, on the other hand, focuses on understanding the causes and consequences of aggressive behavior and the factors that contribute to conflict and violence within social groups.
- In conclusion, social psychology is a rich and multifaceted field that examines the influence of social context on human thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. It explores various processes and phenomena that occur within social groups and provides valuable insights into the complexities of social life. By investigating topics such as social influence, stereotypes and prejudice, group dynamics, and prosocial behavior, social psychology contributes to our understanding of human behavior and offers practical applications for improving interpersonal relationships, promoting cooperation, and reducing conflict within society.

Brief Historical Development of Social Psychology

The historical development of social psychology can be explained in following periods

1. Dawn of social psychology(1862-1934)

The German psychologist Wilhelm Wundt (1832-1921) is viewed as founder of psychology. He was the first psychologist to propose social psychology as a branch of general psychology in 1868. He published many articles under the title of social psychology to explain that a part from mental processes and psychological factors there are social factors that shape human behavior.

The yearwise contribution towards establishment of social psychology are as follows

1898: Norman Triplett conducted first lab experiment to understand mutual impact of actions of individuals and published the results which were later known as social facilitations.

1900: Wilhelm Wundt published first volume to explain social behavior which later on emerged as significant theory of social psychology.

1908: the text books of social psychology were published by William mcdougal, a psychologist and Edward Ross, a sociologist

1920: The first institute of social psychology was founded by Willy Hellpach in Germany.

1924: the third volume of social psychology was published by Floyed Allport which covers the modern areas of social psychology.

1925: the social distance scale was developed by Edward Bogardus to measure an indiv'dual's or group attitude towards another ethnic group.

1934: the known book "mind,self and society" was published by G H Mead which focused on interaction of self and others.

2. Early Stage of social psychology (1935-1945)

1936: The psychology of Social Norms was published by Muzaffar Sherif.

1938: The frustration- aggression hypothesis was introduced by John Dollard to understand the nature of frustration leading to aggression in social interactions.

1941-1945: US govt recruited many social psychologists to help the victims of worldwar and to understand socio psychological factors leading to and controlling wars.

3. Expansion stage of social psychology(1946-1984)

1949: an experiment on attitude change and persuasion,an important area of social psychology was conducted and findings were published by Carl Hovland.

1954: prejudice is an important topic of social psychology that was explored and published by Gordon Allport.

1957: The theory of Cognitive dissonance was published by Leon Festinger. This is important area of subject matter of social psychology.

1958: The psychology of interpersonal relationships was published by fritz heider.

1963: the research findings to explore "Phenomena of obedience towards authoritative individuals" was published by stanley Milgram.

1965: The Society of Experimental Psychology was founded.

1966: The European Association of Experimental Psychology was founded.

1968: The society for personality and social psychology was founded.

1981: A study with title : The meta analysis of gender disparities in behavior was conducted by Alice Eagly.

1985: Shelly Taylor and Susan Fiske published Social Cognition theory to elaborate cognitive perspectives of social psychology.

4. Modern stage of social psychology (1985-onwards)

1986: the theory of communication and persuasion was published by John Cacioppo and Richard Petty. It explains two dimensions of persuasion for an attitude change in social psychology.

1989: an article with title social stigma and self esteem was published by Brenda and Jennifer Crocker. It focuses on how an individual responds to being a target of stigmatizations and discrimination.

1991: an article on important area of social psychology " How cultures shape the self"was published by Shinobu kitayama and Hazel Markus.

1995: an article with the title of stereotype threat and intellectual test performance was published by Joshua Aronson and Claude steele. It explains how negative streotypes shapes intellectual performance and identity.

Scope of Social Psychology

It studies human behavior in groups and that how human behavior is influenced by others. It attempts to understand the socio-psychological causes and motives of human behavior in groups. Social psychology attempts to understand the relationship between minds, groups, and behaviors in three general ways:

- (1) It tries to see how the thoughts, feelings and behaviours of individuals are influenced by the actual, imagined, or implied presence of other(s). This includes social perception, social interaction, and the many kinds of social influence (like trust, power, and persuasion). It deals with questions like: How do small group dynamics impact cognition and emotional states? ▪ How do social groups control or contribute to behaviour, emotion, or attitudes of the individual members? ▪ How does the group impact the individual? ▪ How does the individual operate within the social group?
- (2) Second, it tries to understand the influence that individual perceptions and behaviours have upon the behaviour of groups. This includes looking at things like group productivity in the workplace and group decision making. It looks at questions like: What are the reasons behind consistency, diversity, and deviance?
- (3) Third, and finally, social psychology tries to understand groups themselves as behavioural entities, and the relationships and influences that one group has upon another group. It asks questions like: ▪ What makes some groups hostile to one another, and others neutral or civil? ▪ Do groups behave in a different way than an individual outside the group?

Social psychology and other social sciences

Social Psychology and Sociology

Sociology is defined as the study of society. Sociology is the social science dealing with social system and structures, relationships, institutes and entire societies. The emergence of sociology in the nineteenth century greatly contributed to the development of social psychology. John Stuart Mill, Auguste Comte and others laid the foundation for social psychology by asserting that human social cognition and behaviour could and should be studied scientifically like any other natural science. A sociologist begins with the domain of society and works towards the individual while the social psychologist reverses the order. As far as social psychology is concerned it is sometimes difficult to demarcate it from social psychology with a sharp line as both the disciplines invest most of their resources in the ambiguous middle ground. Social psychology exchanges freely ideas, methods and models with sociology. In fact this exchange is so rich and ubiquitous that it is often difficult to distinguish the two fields. Being the study of individual in a society, the vantage point of social psychology is more prone to the individual and the experimental method. But with the expanding application, social psychology is adopting the other methods like ethnography and qualitative research more popular with the domain of sociology.

. Social Psychology and Anthropology

Broadly considered as to be the scientific study of human beings, Anthropology originated as a discipline in the Darwinian revolution of the middle of the nineteenth century. Underpinning all the anthropological works is the concern of mapping human variation (biological, behavioural and cultural) and to explain, interpret and understand the directions in the development of human behaviour. The main topics of investigation are primitive societies, cultural relativism, unity of human species, human diversity and human evolution.

Social psychology can make good use of the theories about cultures and societies which might assist in the explanation of the individual behaviour in a particular society. Anthropology can give a clear picture of the cultural and social context to a social psychologist.

Social Psychology and Sociolinguistics

Sociolinguistics is the study of language in relation to social factors, including differences of regional, class, and occupational dialect, gender differences, and bilingualism.

Sociolinguistics includes the areas of study which connects language with society. The discipline uses theories and methods from diverse field like psychology, sociology and anthropology to understand language in societies. Sociolinguistics is centrally concerned with methodology. It is firmly based on the observation of actual, preferably spontaneous speech behaviour. The studies within this field have contributed in terms of understanding language uses and behaviours of peoples in society. The study of language contributes not only in terms of language behaviours but the rich data helps in building theories. The field of sociolinguistics equally borrows theories from social psychology to draw inferences about behaviours from the linguistic data.

Research methods in social psychology

1. Descriptive research

Descriptive research methods are used to define the who, what, and where of human behavior and other psychological phenomena. Psychologists and researchers use a myriad of tools when studying human and animal behavior.

Descriptive research methods in psychology are designed to scientifically describe or explain what happens to whom and where, as opposed to how or why it happens.

This type of research is often conducted in a natural setting and may be the precursor to other types of scientific research that delves deeper into a phenomenon.

There are three main methods used in descriptive research, each with their own strengths and weaknesses.

What is descriptive research?

Descriptive research methods are scientific tools used by researchers and psychologists for gathering information and describing the specifics of behaviors, patterns, and other phenomena. These methods focus on the who, what, and where, versus the why or how.

In psychology, descriptive research is used often to define certain behaviors or traits that are observed. Because descriptive research is typically concerned with the “raw truth,” it is often conducted as naturally as possible without introducing any manipulation or variables.

Descriptive research may be an initial step before the other two types of psychological research are conducted:

- **Correlational research:** examines two variables at once, and may be used to identify patterns of relationships
- **Experimental research:** determines cause and effect by exposing one group to a particular variable, while another is not exposed to the variable

Descriptive research does not typically rely on a hypothesis and may be more flexible than the other types of psychological research. This type of research can act as a springboard for further exploration by allowing scientists to gather information needed to form a hypothesis. That hypothesis could then serve as the basis for a correlational study or a formal experiment.

Types of descriptive research in psychology

There are three methods scientists use to obtain descriptive research:

- observation
- case studies
- surveys

Each method comes with strengths and weaknesses. Scientists may opt for one method over another depending on the type of information they need and from whom.

Observational method

The observational method refers to scientists watching the behavior of animals or humans in a natural setting. Researchers may use the data to pinpoint trends or patterns that might warrant further exploration.

The goal of the observational method is to provide an unbiased “snapshot” of a particular population at a particular time, according to a [2020 research review](#) [Trusted Source](#) rating the efficacy of different descriptive research methods.

However, this method must be conducted carefully to garner accurate results. If the subjects being observed are aware someone is watching them, they might become uncomfortable and change their behavior. This is sometimes called “the Hawthorne effect.”

Yet, there are some ways a researcher may be able to mitigate the Hawthorne effect, such as trying to blend in so well that the observers do not notice the researchers, or telling the participant they are observing something different from what they’re actually looking at.

Additionally, researchers may also transmit bias to those they observe, resulting in the participants adjusting their behavior to the bias.

For these reasons, the observational method may be more accurate for scientists studying animal behavior, rather than human.

Case studies

Case studies typically focus on an individual or small group of people and can provide a wealth of information about something very specific in its natural setting.

The goal of this research method is to provide detailed information about a contained phenomenon in a natural environment. For example, a person or small group of people with a rare disease or trait might be observed by a researcher to produce data on that specific disease or trait.

This precision can pose benefits and risks to case studies.

Participants may be less likely to drop out or refuse to follow up with researchers in this type of research format, which can increase the accuracy of case study findings.

And despite the ability case studies have to collect a lot of information about something particular, scientists and researchers may still be unable to generalize their findings to the greater population. Thus, a case study may not be representative, which can make findings unreliable beyond the case study's specific scope.

One challenge of the case study is that the definition of this descriptive research method can vary widely among scientists, across and even within disciplines. Yet, some scientists suggest that case studies can and should be used more broadly, as one [2020 paper](#) [Trusted Source](#) argues.

Surveys

When a broad sample size is needed to assess specific information, a researcher's best tool may be a survey. The goal of a survey is to gain insight into a particular behavior among a large group of people.

Survey research involves participants responding to researchers' questions through questionnaires, virtually or in person. Surveys can assess a broader variety of people in their sample than a case study, but cannot provide the same depth of information.

As a descriptive research method, surveys can have similar inaccuracies to observation. Participants may change their answers out of concern or fear for how they could be perceived.

Virtual versus in-person surveys

Online surveys may be more accurate because participants are not answering questions face-to-face with an interviewer. However, because no interviewer is present, answers cannot be discussed beyond what is provided.

Online surveys may also have lower response rates. In-person interviews might provide better response rates, but are often more expensive to produce. Phone interviews may be faster and cheaper, but are commonly less in-depth and risk participants dropping out.

Let's recap

Descriptive research methods can be crucial for psychological researchers to establish and describe the natural details of a particular phenomenon.

There are three major methods of descriptive research:

- observation
- case studies
- surveys

correlational research

correlational study is a type of research design that looks at the relationships between two or more variables. Correlational studies are non-experimental, which means that the experimenter does not manipulate or control any of the variables.

A correlation refers to a relationship between two variables.¹ [Correlations can be strong or weak](#) and positive or negative. Sometimes, there is no correlation.

There are three possible outcomes of a correlation study: a positive correlation, a negative correlation, or no correlation. Researchers can present the results using a numerical value called the correlation coefficient, a measure of the correlation strength. It can range from -1.00 (negative) to $+1.00$ (positive). A correlation coefficient of 0 indicates no correlation.²

- **Positive correlations:** Both variables increase or decrease at the same time. A correlation coefficient close to $+1.00$ indicates a strong positive correlation.
- **Negative correlations:** As the amount of one variable increases, the other decreases (and vice versa). A correlation coefficient close to -1.00 indicates a strong negative correlation.
- **No correlation:** There is no relationship between the two variables. A correlation coefficient of 0 indicates no correlation.
- Characteristics of a Correlational Study
- Correlational studies are often used in psychology, as well as other fields like medicine.³ Correlational research is a preliminary way to gather information about a topic. The method is also useful if researchers are unable to perform an experiment.
- Researchers use correlations to see if a relationship between two or more variables exists, but the variables themselves are not under the control of the researchers.
- While correlational research can demonstrate a relationship between variables, it cannot prove that changing one variable will change another. In other words, correlational studies cannot prove cause-and-effect relationships.⁴

Types of correlational research

1. Naturalistic observation

Naturalistic observation is an approach to data collection that involves observing people's behaviour in the environment in which it typically occurs. Thus naturalistic observation is a type of field research (as opposed to a type of laboratory research). It could involve observing shoppers in a grocery store, children on a school playground, or psychiatric inpatients in their wards. Researchers engaged in naturalistic observation usually make their observations as unobtrusively as possible so that participants are often not aware that they are being studied. Ethically, this method is considered to be acceptable if the participants remain anonymous and the behaviour occurs in a public setting where people would not normally have an expectation of privacy. Grocery shoppers putting items into their shopping carts, for example, are engaged in public behaviour that is easily observable by store employees and other shoppers. For this reason, most researchers would consider it ethically acceptable to observe them for a study. On the other hand, one of the arguments against the ethicality of the naturalistic observation of "bathroom behaviour" discussed earlier in the book is that people have a reasonable expectation of privacy even in a public restroom and that this expectation was violated.

Advantages

- Can inspire ideas for further research
- Option if lab experiment not available
- Variables are viewed in natural setting

Disadvantages

- Can be time-consuming and expensive
- Extraneous variables can't be controlled
- No scientific control of variables
- Subjects might behave differently if aware of being observed
- This method is well-suited to studies where researchers want to see how variables behave in their natural setting or state.⁴ Inspiration can then be drawn from the observations to inform future avenues of research.
- In some cases, it might be the only method available to researchers; for example, if lab experimentation would be precluded by access, resources, or ethics. It might be preferable to not being able to conduct research at all, but the method can be costly and usually takes a lot of time.⁴
- Naturalistic observation presents several challenges for researchers. For one, it does not allow them to control or influence the [variables](#) in any way nor can they change any possible external variables.
- However, this does not mean that researchers will get reliable data from watching the variables, or that the information they gather will be free from bias.
- For example, study subjects might act differently if they know that they are being watched. The researchers might not be aware that the behavior that they are observing is not necessarily the subject's natural state (i.e., how they would act if they did not know they were being watched).
- Researchers also need to be aware of their biases, which can affect the observation and interpretation of a subject's behavior

2. Surveys

Surveys and questionnaires are some of the most common methods used for psychological research. The survey method involves having a [random sample](#) of participants complete a survey, test, or questionnaire related to the variables of interest.¹ Random sampling is vital to the generalizability of a survey's results.

Advantages

- Cheap, easy, and fast
- Can collect large amounts of data in a short amount of time
- Flexible

Disadvantages

- Results can be affected by poor survey questions
- Results can be affected by unrepresentative sample
- Outcomes can be affected by participants

If researchers need to gather a large amount of data in a short period of time, a survey is likely to be the fastest, easiest, and cheapest option.¹

It's also a flexible method because it lets researchers create data-gathering tools that will help ensure they get the information they need (survey responses) from all the sources they want to use (a random sample of participants taking the survey).

Survey data might be cost-efficient and easy to get, but it has its downsides. For one, the data is not always reliable—particularly if the survey questions are poorly written or the overall design or delivery is weak.² Data is also affected by specific faults, such as unrepresented or underrepresented [samples](#).

The use of surveys relies on participants to provide useful data. Researchers need to be aware of the specific factors related to the people taking the survey that will affect its outcome.

For example, some people might struggle to understand the questions. A person might answer a particular way to try to please the researchers or to try to control how the researchers perceive them (such as trying to make themselves "look better").

Sometimes, respondents might not even realize that their answers are incorrect or misleading because of [mistaken memories](#).

3. Archival Research

Many areas of psychological research benefit from analyzing studies that were conducted long ago by other researchers, as well as reviewing historical records and case studies.¹

For example, in an experiment known as "[The Irritable Heart](#)," researchers used digitalized records containing information on American Civil War veterans to learn more about post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).⁵

Advantages

- Large amount of data
- Can be less expensive
- Researchers cannot change participant behavior

Disadvantages

- Can be unreliable
- Information might be missing
- No control over data collection methods

Using records, databases, and libraries that are publicly accessible or accessible through their institution can help researchers who might not have a lot of money to support their research efforts.

Free and low-cost resources are available to researchers at all levels through academic institutions, museums, and data repositories around the world.

Another potential benefit is that these sources often provide an enormous amount of data that was collected over a very long period of time, which can give researchers a way to view trends, relationships, and outcomes related to their research.¹

While the inability to change variables can be a disadvantage of some methods, it can be a benefit of archival research. That said, using historical records or information that was collected a long time ago also presents challenges. For one, important information might be missing or incomplete and some aspects of older studies might not be useful to researchers in a modern context.

A primary issue with archival research is reliability.⁴ When reviewing old research, little information might be available about who conducted the research, how a study was designed, who participated in the research, as well as how data was collected and interpreted.

Researchers can also be presented with ethical quandaries—for example, should modern researchers use data from studies that were conducted unethically or with questionable ethics?

Experimental Research

Experimental research is the key to uncovering causal relationships between [variables](#). In experimental research, the experimenter randomly assigns participants to one of two groups:

- **The control group:** The control group receives no treatment and serves as a baseline.
- **The experimental group:** Researchers manipulate the levels of some [independent variable](#) in the experimental group and then measure the effects.

Because researchers are able to control the independent variables, experimental research can be used to find causal relationships between variables.

So if psychologists wanted to establish a causal relationship between media violence and aggressive behavior, they would want to design an [experiment](#) to test this hypothesis. If the [hypothesis](#) was that playing violent video games causes players to respond more aggressively in social situations, they would want to randomly assign participants to two groups.

The control group would play a non-violent video game for a predetermined period of time while the experimental group would play a violent game for the same period of time.

Afterward, the participants would be placed in a situation where they would play a game against another opponent. In this game, they could either respond aggressively or non-aggressively. The researchers would then collect data on how often people utilized aggressive responses in this situation and then compare this information with whether these individuals were in the control or experimental group.

By using the scientific method, designing an experiment, collecting data, and analyzing the results, researchers can then determine if there is a causal relationship between media violence and violent behavior.

Survey

A survey is a data collection tool used to gather information about individuals. Surveys are commonly used in [psychology research](#) to collect [self-report](#) data from study participants. A survey may focus on factual information about individuals, or it might aim to obtain the opinions of the survey takers.¹

Psychology surveys involve asking participants a series of questions to learn more about a phenomenon, such as how they think, feel, or behave. Such tools can be helpful for learning about behaviors, conditions, traits, or other topics that interest researchers.

Reasons to use survey in social psychology

- Understand the experiences, opinions, and behaviors of the participants
- Evaluate respondent attitudes and beliefs
- Look at the risk factors in a sample
- Assess individual differences
- Evaluate the success of interventions or preventative programs

How to use surveys in social psychology

How Surveys Are Administered

A survey can be administered in a couple of different ways:

- **Structured interview:** The researcher asks each participant the questions
- **Questionnaire:** the participant fills out the survey independently

Advantages of surveys

- **Data collection:** Surveys allow researchers to collect a large amount of data in a relatively short period.
- **Cost-effectiveness:** Surveys are less expensive than many other data collection techniques.
- **Ease of administration:** Surveys can be created quickly and administered easily.
- **Usefulness:** Surveys can be used to collect information on a broad range of things, including personal facts, attitudes, past behaviors, and opinions.

Disadvantages of surveys

- **Problems with construction and administration:** Poor survey construction and administration can undermine otherwise well-designed studies.
- **Inaccuracy:** The answer choices provided in a survey may not be an accurate reflection of how the participants actually feel.
- **Poor response rates:** While [random sampling](#) is generally used to select participants, response rates can bias the results of a survey. Strategies to improve response rates sometimes include offering financial incentives, sending personalized invitations, and reminding participants to complete the survey.⁶
- **Biased results:** The social desirability bias can lead people to respond in a way that makes them look better than they really are.⁷ For example, a respondent might report that they engage in more healthy behaviors than they do in real life.

Important consideration when using surveys

- **Obtaining [informed consent](#) is vital:** Before administering a psychological survey, all participants should be informed about the purpose and potential risks before responding.
- **Creating a representative sample:** Researchers should ensure that their participant sample is representative of the larger population. This involves including participants who are part of diverse populations.
- **Participation must be voluntary:** Anyone who responds to a survey must do so of their own free will. They should not feel coerced or bribed into participating.
- **Take steps to reduce bias:** Questions should be carefully constructed so they do not affect how the participants respond. Researchers should also be cautious to avoid insensitive or offensive questions.
- **Confidentiality:** All survey responses should be kept confidential. Researchers often utilize special software that ensures privacy, protects data, and avoids using identifiable information.

Interview method

1. Structured interview

A structured interview is a quantitative research method where the interviewer asks a set of prepared closed-ended questions in the form of an interview schedule, which he/she reads out exactly as worded.

The interviewer will not deviate from the interview schedule (except to clarify the meaning of the question) or probe beyond the answers received. Replies are recorded on a questionnaire, and the order and wording of questions, and sometimes the range of alternative answers, is preset by the researcher.

A structured interview is also known as a formal interview (like a job interview).

Strengths

1. Structured interviews are easy to replicate as a fixed set of closed questions are used, which are easy to quantify – this means it is easy to test for [reliability](#).
2. Structured interviews are fairly quick to conduct which means that many interviews can take place within a short amount of time. This means a large sample can be obtained, resulting in the findings being representative and having the ability to be generalized to a large population.

Limitations

1. Structured interviews are not flexible. This means new questions cannot be asked impromptu (i.e., during the interview), as an interview schedule must be followed.
2. The answers from structured interviews lack detail as only closed questions are asked, which generates [quantitative data](#). This means a researcher won't know why a person behaves a certain way.

Unstructured Interview

Unstructured interviews do not use any set questions, instead, the interviewer asks open-ended questions based on a specific research topic, and will try to let the interview flow like a natural conversation. The interviewer modifies his or her questions to suit the candidate's specific experiences.

Unstructured interviews are sometimes referred to as 'discovery interviews' and are more like a 'guided conversation' than a strictly structured interview. They are sometimes called informal interviews.

Unstructured interviews are most useful in **qualitative research** to analyze attitudes and values. Though they rarely provide a valid basis for generalization, their main advantage is that they enable the researcher to probe social actors' subjective points of view.

Interviewer Self-Disclosure

Interviewer self-disclosure involves the interviewer revealing personal information or opinions during the research interview. This may increase rapport but risks changing dynamics away from a focus on facilitating the interviewee's account.

In unstructured interviews, the informal conversational style may deliberately include elements of interviewer self-disclosure, mirroring ordinary conversation dynamics.

Interviewer self-disclosure risks changing the dynamics away from facilitation of interviewee accounts. It should not be ruled out entirely but requires skillful handling informed by reflection.

- An informal interviewing style with some interviewer self-disclosure may increase rapport and participant openness. However, it also increases the chance of the participant converging opinions with the interviewer.
- Complete interviewer neutrality is unlikely. However, excessive informality and self-disclosure risk the interview becoming more of an ordinary conversation and producing consensus accounts.
- Overly personal disclosures could also be seen as irrelevant and intrusive by participants. They may invite increased intimacy on uncomfortable topics.
- The safest approach seems to be to avoid interviewer self-disclosures in most cases. Where an informal style is used, disclosures require careful judgment and substantial interviewing experience.
- If asked for personal opinions during an interview, the interviewer could highlight the defined roles and defer that discussion until after the interview.

Strengths

1. Unstructured interviews are more flexible as questions can be adapted and changed depending on the respondents' answers. The interview can deviate from the interview schedule.

2. Unstructured interviews generate qualitative data through the use of open questions. This allows the respondent to talk in some depth, choosing their own words. This helps the researcher develop a real sense of a person's understanding of a situation.
3. They also have increased **validity** because it gives the interviewer the opportunity to probe for a deeper understanding, ask for clarification & allow the interviewee to steer the direction of the interview, etc. Interviewers have the chance to clarify any questions of participants during the interview.

Limitations

1. It can be time-consuming to conduct an unstructured interview and analyze the qualitative data (using methods such as thematic analysis).
2. Employing and training interviewers is expensive and not as cheap as collecting data via **questionnaires**. For example, certain skills may be needed by the interviewer. These include the ability to establish rapport and knowing when to probe.
3. Interviews inevitably co-construct data through researchers' agenda-setting and question-framing. Techniques like open questions provide only limited remedies.



Focus Group Interview

Focus group interview is a qualitative approach where a group of respondents are interviewed together, used to gain an in-depth understanding of social issues.

This type of interview is often referred to as a focus group because the job of the interviewer (or moderator) is to bring the group to focus on the issue at hand. Initially, the goal was to reach a consensus among the group, but with the development of techniques for analyzing group qualitative data, there is less emphasis on consensus building.

The method aims to obtain data from a purposely selected group of individuals rather than from a statistically representative sample of a broader population.

The role of the interview moderator is to make sure the group interacts with each other and do not drift off-topic. Ideally, the moderator will be similar to the participants in terms of appearance, have adequate knowledge of the topic being discussed, and exercise mild unobtrusive control over dominant talkers and shy participants.

A researcher must be highly skilled to conduct a focus group interview. For example, the moderator may need certain skills, including the ability to establish rapport and know when to probe.

Strengths

1. Group interviews generate qualitative narrative data through the use of open questions. This allows the respondents to talk in some depth, choosing their own words. This helps the researcher develop a real sense of a person's understanding of a situation. Qualitative data also includes observational data, such as body language and facial expressions.
2. Group responses are helpful when you want to elicit perspectives on a collective experience, encourage diversity of thought, reduce researcher bias, and gather a wider range of contextualized views.
3. They also have increased **validity** because some participants may feel more comfortable being with others as they are used to talking in groups in real life (i.e., it's more natural).
4. When participants have common experiences, focus groups allow them to build on each other's comments to provide richer contextual data representing a wider range of views than individual interviews.
5. Focus groups are a type of group interview method used in market research and consumer psychology that are cost-effective for gathering the views of consumers.

Limitations

1. The researcher must ensure that they keep all the interviewees' details confidential and respect their privacy. This is difficult when using a group interview. For example, the researcher cannot guarantee that the other people in the group will keep information private.
2. Group interviews are less **reliable** as they use open questions and may deviate from the interview schedule, making them difficult to repeat.
3. It is important to note that there are some potential pitfalls of focus groups, such as conformity, social desirability, and oppositional behavior, that can reduce the usefulness of the data collected.

For example, group interviews may sometimes lack **validity** as participants may lie to impress the other group members. They may conform to peer pressure and give false answers.

To avoid these pitfalls, the interviewer needs to have a good understanding of how people function in groups as well as how to lead the group in a productive discussion.

Semi-Structured Interview

Semi-structured interviews lie between structured and unstructured interviews. The interviewer prepares a set of some questions to be answered by all interviewees. Additional questions might be asked during the interview to clarify or expand certain issues.

In semi-structured interviews, the interviewer has more freedom to digress and probe beyond the answers. The interview guide contains a list of questions and topics that need to be covered during the conversation, usually in a particular order.

Semi-structured interviews are most useful to address the ‘what’, ‘how’, and ‘why’ research questions. Both **qualitative and quantitative analyses** can be performed on data collected during semi-structured interviews.

Strengths

1. Semi-structured interviews allow respondents to answer more on their terms in an informal setting yet provide uniform information making them ideal for qualitative analysis.
2. The flexible nature of semi-structured interviews allows ideas to be introduced and explored during the interview based on the respondents’ answers.
3. Semi-structured interviews can provide reliable and comparable qualitative data. Allows the interviewer to probe answers, where the interviewee is asked to clarify or expand on the answers provided.

Limitations

1. The data generated remain fundamentally shaped by the interview context itself. Analysis rarely acknowledges this endemic co-construction.
2. They are more time-consuming (to conduct, transcribe, and analyze) than structured interviews.
3. The quality of findings is more dependent on the individual skills of the interviewer than in structured interviews. Skill is required to probe effectively while avoiding biasing responses.

The Interviewer Effect

Face-to-face interviews raise methodological problems. These stem from the fact that interviewers are themselves role players, and their perceived status may influence the replies of the respondents.

Because an interview is a social interaction, the interviewer’s appearance or behavior may influence the respondent’s answers. This is a problem as it can bias the results of the study and make them invalid.

For example, the gender, ethnicity, body language, age, and social status of the interviewer can all create an interviewer effect. If there is a perceived status disparity between the interviewer and the interviewee, the results of interviews have to be interpreted with care. This is pertinent for sensitive topics such as health.

For example, if a researcher was investigating sexism amongst males, would a female interview be preferable to a male? It is possible that if a female interviewer was used, male participants might lie (i.e., pretend they are not sexist) to impress the interviewer, thus creating an interviewer effect.

Interview Design

First, you must choose whether to use a structured or non-structured interview.

Characteristics of Interviewers

Next, you must consider who will be the interviewer, and this will depend on what type of person is being interviewed. There are several variables to consider:

- **Gender and age:** This can greatly affect respondents' answers, particularly on personal issues.
- **Personal characteristics:** Some people are easier to get on with than others. Also, the interviewer's accent and appearance (e.g., clothing) can affect the rapport between the interviewer and interviewee.
- **Language:** The interviewer's language should be appropriate to the vocabulary of the group of people being studied. For example, the researcher must change the questions' language to match the respondents' social background" age / educational level / social class/ethnicity, etc.
- **Ethnicity:** People may have difficulty interviewing people from different ethnic groups.
- **Interviewer expertise** should match research sensitivity – inexperienced students should avoid interviewing highly vulnerable groups.

Interview Location

The location of a research interview can influence the way in which the interviewer and interviewee relate and may exaggerate a power dynamic in one direction or another. It is usual to offer interviewees a choice of location as part of facilitating their comfort and encouraging participation.

However, the safety of the interviewer is an overriding consideration and, as mentioned, a minimal requirement should be that a responsible person knows where the interviewer has gone and when they are due back.

Remote Interviews

The COVID-19 pandemic necessitated remote interviewing for research continuity. However online interview platforms provide increased flexibility even under normal conditions.

They enable access to participant groups across geographical distances without travel costs or arrangements. Online interviews can be efficiently scheduled to align with researcher and interviewee availability.

There are practical considerations in setting up remote interviews. Interviewees require access to internet and an online platform such as Zoom, Microsoft Teams or Skype through which to connect.

Certain modifications help build initial rapport in the remote format. Allowing time at the start of the interview for casual conversation while testing audio/video quality helps participants settle in. Minor delays can disrupt turn-taking flow, so alerting participants to speak slightly slower than usual minimizes accidental interruptions.

Keeping remote interviews under an hour avoids fatigue for stare at a screen. Seeking advanced ethical clearance for verbal consent at the interview start saves participant time. Adapting to the remote context shows care for interviewees and aids rich discussion.

However, it remains important to critically reflect on how removing in-person dynamics may shape the co-created data. Perhaps some nuances of trust and disclosure differ over video.

Vulnerable Groups

The interviewer must ensure that they take special care when interviewing vulnerable groups, such as children. For example, children have a limited attention span, so lengthy interviews should be avoided.

Developing An Interview Schedule

An interview schedule is a list of pre-planned, structured questions that have been prepared, to serve as a guide for interviewers, researchers and investigators in collecting information or data about a specific topic or issue.

1. List the key themes or topics that must be covered to address your research questions. This will form the basic content.
2. Organize the content logically, such as chronologically following the interviewee's experiences. Place more sensitive topics later in the interview.
3. Develop the list of content into actual questions and prompts. Carefully word each question – keep them open-ended, non-leading, and focused on examples.
4. Add prompts to remind you to cover areas of interest.

5. **Pilot test** the interview schedule to check it generates useful data and revise as needed.
6. Be prepared to refine the schedule throughout data collection as you learn which questions work better.
7. Practice skills like asking follow-up questions to get depth and detail. Stay flexible to depart from the schedule when needed.
8. Keep questions brief and clear. Avoid multi-part questions that risk confusing interviewees.
9. Listen actively during interviews to determine which pre-planned questions can be skipped based on information the participant has already provided.

The key is balancing preparation with the flexibility to adapt questions based on each interview interaction. With practice, you'll gain skills to conduct productive interviews that obtain rich qualitative data.

The Power Of Silence

Strategic use of silence is a key technique to generate interviewee-led data, but it requires judgment about appropriate timing and duration to maintain mutual understanding.

- Unlike ordinary conversation, the interviewer aims to facilitate the interviewee's contribution without interrupting. This often means resisting the urge to speak at the end of the interviewee's turn construction units (TCUs).
- Leaving a silence after a TCU encourages the interviewee to provide more material without being led by the interviewer. However, this simple technique requires confidence, as silence can feel socially awkward.
- Allowing longer silences (e.g. 24 seconds) later in interviews can work well, but early on even short silences may disrupt rapport if they cause misalignment between speakers.
- Silence also allows interviewees time to think before answering. Rushing to re-ask or amend questions can limit responses.
- Blunt backchannels like "mm hm" also avoid interrupting flow. Interruptions, especially to finish an interviewee's turn, are problematic as they make the ownership of perspectives unclear.
- If interviewers incorrectly complete turns, an upside is it can produce extended interviewee narratives correcting the record. However, silence would have been better to let interviewees shape their own accounts.

Recording & Transcription

Design choices

Design choices around recording and engaging closely with transcripts influence analytic insights, as well as practical feasibility. Weighing up relevant tradeoffs is key.

1. Audio recording is standard, but video better captures contextual details, which is useful for some topics/analysis approaches. Participants may find video invasive for sensitive research.
2. Digital formats enable the sharing of anonymized clips. Additional microphones reduce audio issues.
3. Doing all transcription is time-consuming. Outsourcing can save researcher effort but needs confidentiality assurances. Always carefully check outsourced transcripts.
4. Online platform auto-captioning can facilitate rapid analysis, but accuracy limitations mean full transcripts remain ideal. Software cleans up caption file formatting.
5. Verbatim transcripts best capture nuanced meaning, but the level of detail needed depends on the analysis approach. Referring back to recordings is still advisable during analysis.
6. Transcripts versus recordings highlight different interaction elements. Transcripts make overt disagreements clearer through the wording itself. Recordings better convey tone affiliativeness.

Ethical Issues

Informed Consent

The participant information sheet must give potential interviewees a good idea of what is involved if taking part in the research.

This will include the general topics covered in the interview, where the interview might take place, how long it is expected to last, how it will be recorded, the ways in which participants' anonymity will be managed, and incentives offered.

It might be considered good practice to consider true informed consent in interview research to require two distinguishable stages:

1. Consent to undertake and record the interview and

2. Consent to use the material in research after the interview has been conducted and the content known, or even after the interviewee has seen a copy of the transcript and has had a chance to remove sections, if desired.

Power and Vulnerability

- Early feminist views that sensitivity could equalize power differences are likely naive. The interviewer and interviewee inhabit different knowledge spheres and social categories, indicating structural disparities.
- Power fluctuates within interviews. Researchers rely on participation, yet interviewees control openness and can undermine data collection. Assumptions should be avoided.
- Interviews on sensitive topics may feel like quasi-counseling. Interviewers must refrain from dual roles, instead supplying support service details to all participants.
- Interviewees recruited for trauma experiences may reveal more than anticipated. While generating analytic insights, this risks leaving them feeling exposed.
- Ultimately, power balances resist reconciliation. But reflexively analyzing operations of power serves to qualify rather than nullify situated qualitative accounts.

Vulnerable Groups

Some groups, like those with mental health issues, extreme views, or criminal backgrounds, risk being discredited – treated skeptically by researchers.

This creates tensions with [qualitative approaches](#), often having an empathetic ethos seeking to center subjective perspectives. Analysis should balance openness to offered accounts with critically examining stakes and motivations behind them.

Content analysis

- Identify the intentions, focus or communication trends of an individual, group or institution
- Describe attitudinal and behavioral responses to communications
- Determine the psychological or emotional state of persons or groups
- Reveal international differences in communication content
- Reveal patterns in communication content
- Pre-test and improve an intervention or survey prior to launch
- Analyze focus group interviews and open-ended questions to complement quantitative data

Advantages of Content Analysis

- Directly examines communication using text
- Allows for both qualitative and quantitative analysis
- Provides valuable historical and cultural insights over time
- Allows a closeness to data

- Coded form of the text can be statistically analyzed
- Unobtrusive means of analyzing interactions
- Provides insight into complex models of human thought and language use
- When done well, is considered a relatively “exact” research method
- Content analysis is a readily-understood and an inexpensive research method
- A more powerful tool when combined with other research methods such as interviews, observation, and use of archival records. It is very useful for analyzing historical material, especially for documenting trends over time.

Disadvantages of Content Analysis

- Can be extremely time consuming
- Is subject to increased error, particularly when relational analysis is used to attain a higher level of interpretation
- Is often devoid of theoretical base, or attempts too liberally to draw meaningful inferences about the relationships and impacts implied in a study
- Is inherently reductive, particularly when dealing with complex texts
- Tends too often to simply consist of word counts
- Often disregards the context that produced the text, as well as the state of things after the text is produced
- Can be difficult to automate or computerize

Cross-cultural research

is a systematic study investigating cultural differences in behaviour and phenomenon between two or more cultures.

There are clear distinctions that are observable between Western and Eastern societies. **Western society** is also known as an **individualistic society**. It is characterised by a focus on individual rights and own happiness.

Typical behaviours of people in this society are that they voice their opinion, are independent and tend to do things their way.

Eastern society is also known as a **collectivist society**. It is characterised by a focus on the superiority of the collective community and emphasises social support. People in eastern societies are typically reserved and hold traditional views.

Typical behaviours within a collective society usually conform to societal rules and have social harmony, so they are less likely to be openly aggressive towards others.

The two cultures may have contrasting opinions of what dysfunctional behaviour is. Therefore, when assessing mental health, there may be differences. Cross-cultural research can be carried out to identify differences between individualistic and collectivist societies.

Types of Cross-Cultural Research

Cross-cultural research allows researchers to identify if findings apply to the target/broader population. There are three main types of cross-cultural research, these are:

Psychological Method Validation of Cross-Cultural Research

This type of cross-cultural research is typically used when researchers want to identify if psychological measures/ tests are applicable and generalisable to the population. For instance, if it takes into account cultural differences.

Research by Mandy, Charman, Puura and Skuse (2014) applied the DSM-5 (the manual used for mental illness diagnosis in the UK) to see if it considers the difference between British and Finnish people.

The study found that there may be cross-cultural variability between the two countries regarding milder autistic characteristics.

The research highlights the importance of cross-cultural research as it shows that well-established measures may not apply to the entire population. If similar results are found across cultures, then it can be assumed that the measures are:

- **Valid:** measuring what it is supposed to measure.
- **Reliable:** all of the items/ questions/ scales are consistent.

Indigenous Cultural Studies

Indigenous cultural studies are the study of minority ethnic groups who live in their native location. These individuals tend to have their rituals, traditions and language, and research has also found developmental differences.

The research can take the form of cross-cultural research if the results of indigenous populations are compared to people from other countries. The purpose of this research could be to identify the similarities and differences between populations.

In some minority populations in Papua New Guinea, Turkey and the Dominican Republic, it has been found that some children identified as female at birth. Still, at the age of 12 (after the onset of puberty), they started to develop male genitalia.

The indigenous cultural study highlights the importance of cross-cultural research as it shows how differences between nature and nurture factors between cultures could lead to this type of intersexuality.

Cross-Cultural Comparisons

A cross-cultural comparison study compares the findings of two or more countries. This research design can be used to find similarities and differences across cultures or identify if findings support/disprove hypotheses in different cultures.

Usually, this research method is used when we're trying to investigate if one culture will have significantly different (lower or higher) scores compared to another.

A cross-cultural research example that takes a comparative approach is **Van Ijzendoorn and Kroonenberg's (1988)** study. This study compares the prevalence of [attachment](#) styles across eight countries

Cross-Cultural Research Methodologies

The cross-cultural methodology consists of the following steps:

Step 1: Identify the research area that will be investigated and form a hypothesis.

Step 2: Choosing the appropriate cross-cultural design that will be used.

Step 3: Carry out the research.

Step 4: Carry out the analysis and report the results.

A cross-cultural comparison methodology will be used if the researcher aims to compare results across cultures. And if the researcher is investigating indigenous populations, then an indigenous cultural study would be done. In contrast, if researchers investigate if a psychological test takes cultural differences into account, then a psychological method validation of cross-cultural research would be carried out.

Strengths of Cross-Cultural Research

Cross-cultural research is important because it helps reduce the bias in the current psychology research. Some research may infer theories as universal. This can be supported if cross-cultural research establishes similar results across cultures. This is important because it allows researchers to identify if results are generalisable and if they can be applied to understand the population rather than a sub-group of the population.

Through cross-cultural research, researchers can identify how much culture influences behaviour and mental illnesses. It allows researchers to determine if tools used to measure things such as mental illnesses or systems created for diagnosing mental illnesses are acceptable to use in other countries. If this is not the case, then the systems being used may need to be revised.

Problems with Cross-Cultural Research

The problems with cross-cultural research include that cross-cultural research is sensitive.

If the researcher uses 20 American studies and three studies from China, the results are more likely to reflect the American population than the Chinese population.

Therefore, the cross-cultural research will not provide generalisable results. It needs to use people from different cultures to be considered generalisable equally. In addition, if the researcher chooses a cross-cultural methodology that requires them to collect data independently, this can be costly and time-consuming.

As some cross-cultural research methodologies rely on secondary data (findings from previously published studies), the validity and findings from these studies can affect cross-cultural research results. It

can be a difficult process to carry out. For instance, tools may not be readily available in other countries, or there may be language barriers.

Additionally, researchers require a large sample to find meaningful results, which can be tricky. Results may be misinterpreted due to the above issues and suffer from being ethnocentric.

Smith and Bond (1988) highlighted issues using similar methodologies across cultures. They argued one culture may find a specific tool, reference, or way of behaving familiar and acceptable, whilst another may not have come across it before, so using the same methodology to increase reliability and validity may cause issues with validity.

Concept of self in social psychology

The self-concept is a general term for how someone thinks about, evaluates, or perceives themselves. To be aware of oneself is to have a concept of oneself.

It's formed through experiences, interactions, and reflections, and plays a pivotal role in influencing behavior, emotions, and interpersonal relationships. A healthy self-concept promotes well-being, while a negative one can lead to emotional and social challenges.

Baumeister (1999) provides the following self-concept definition: "The individual's belief about himself or herself, including the person's attributes and who and what the self is."

Aspects Lewis (1990) suggests that the development of a concept of self has two aspects:

(1) The Existential Self

This is "the most basic part of the self-scheme or self-concept; the sense of being separate and distinct from others and the awareness of the constancy of the self" (Bee, 1992).

The existential self is a concept within developmental psychology, particularly in the study of infant development. It refers to the basic and most fundamental understanding that an individual exists as a separate and distinct entity from others.

This realization typically begins in infancy, as early as a few months old, when a baby recognizes its existence apart from the external world.

The child realizes that they exist as a separate entity from others and continue to exist over time and space.

The existential self is the foundation upon which more complex aspects of self-concept, like the categorical self (understanding oneself in terms of categorical memberships like gender, skills, and age), are built.

According to Lewis (1990), awareness of the existential self begins as young as two to three months old and arises in part due to the child's relationship with the world. For example, the child smiles, and someone smiles back, or the child touches a mobile and sees it move.

(2) The Categorical Self

Having realized that he or she exists as a separate experiencing being, the child becomes aware that he or she is also an object in the world.

The categorical self involves the understanding that one can be categorized into various groups based on traits, roles, and attributes.

Just as other objects, including people, have properties that can be experienced (big, small, red, smooth, and so on), so the child is becoming aware of himself or herself as an object which can be experienced and which has properties.

The self, too, can be put into categories such as age, gender, size, or skill. Two of the first categories to be applied are age ("I am 3") and gender ("I am a girl").

In early childhood, the categories children apply to themselves are very concrete (e.g., hair color, height, and favorite things). Later, self-description also begins to include reference to internal psychological traits, comparative evaluations, and how others see them.

For instance, a child might identify as being a "big boy" or "big girl," differentiate themselves by saying they have "brown hair," or later recognize they are "good at drawing." The categorical self lays the foundation for more intricate self-identifications as one matures.

Components of self concept according to carl rogers:

1. Self-Image

Self-image refers to the mental representation or picture that individuals have of themselves, encompassing both physical appearance and personal traits.

It's how people perceive themselves and believe others perceive them. Personal experiences, interactions with others, societal standards, and media influences, can shape this perception.

This does not necessarily have to reflect reality. Indeed, a person with anorexia who is thin may have a self-image in which the person believes they are fat.

A person's self-image is affected by many factors, such as parental influences, friends, the media, etc.

Self-image is a significant component of one's overall self-concept and is crucial to self-esteem and confidence. It can influence behavior, choices, relationships, and overall mental well-being. Over time, a person's self-image can change based on experiences, feedback, achievements, and personal reflections.

The Twenty Statements Test

Kuhn (1960) investigated the self-image by using *The Twenty Statements Test*.

He asked people to answer “Who am I?” in 20 different ways.

He found that the responses could be divided into two major groups. These were *social roles* (external or objective aspects of oneself such as son, teacher, friend) and *personality traits* (internal or affective aspects of oneself such as gregarious, impatient, humorous).

The list of answers to the question “Who Am I?” probably includes examples of each of the following four types of responses:

1. **Physical Description:** I’m tall, have blue eyes...etc.
2. **Social Roles:** We are all social beings whose behavior is shaped to some extent by the roles we play. Such roles as student, housewife, or member of the football team not only help others to recognize us but also help us to know what is expected of us in various situations.
3. **Personal Traits:** These are the third dimension of our self-descriptions. “I’m impulsive...I’m generous...I tend to worry a lot,”...etc.
4. **Existential Statements** (abstract ones): These can range from “I’m a child of the universe” to “I’m a human being” to “I’m a spiritual being, “...etc.

Typically, young people describe themselves more in terms of personal traits, whereas older people feel defined to a greater extent by their social roles.

Actual Self

The actual self is how individuals currently see themselves based on their self-awareness and introspection. It represents the attributes, roles, competencies, and characteristics that a person believes they genuinely possess at the present moment.

While “actual self” and “self-image” are closely related and often used interchangeably in casual discussions, they are distinct concepts within the realm of psychology. Here’s a breakdown of the differences:

1. **Actual Self:**
 - Represents an individual’s current perception of themselves based on attributes, roles, and abilities they believe they genuinely possess.

- Serves as a baseline for comparison with other self-representations, like the ideal self or ought self.

2. Self-Image(Real self)

- Refers to the mental representation or picture an individual has of themselves.
- It encompasses both physical appearance and perceived personal traits.
- Self-image is about how people perceive themselves and how they believe they are seen by others.

In essence, the “actual self” is a broader construct that might include one’s self-image as a component.

The actual self covers the entirety of an individual’s current self-perception, while the self-image focuses more on the visual or representational aspect and perceived traits.

Both, however, are integral parts of an individual’s overall self-concept.

2. Self-Esteem

Self-esteem (also known as self-worth) refers to the extent to which we like, accept, or approve of ourselves or how much we value ourselves.

Self-esteem always involves a degree of evaluation, and we may have either a positive or a negative view of ourselves.

Factors influencing self-esteem include:

- Childhood experiences
- Feedback from others
- Comparisons with peers
- Societal standards and cultural influences
- Personal achievements or failures

High Self-Esteem: Individuals with high self-esteem generally believe that they have good qualities and value themselves positively. They often handle life challenges better, are more resilient, and have a positive outlook on life.

- Confidence in our own abilities

- Self-acceptance
- Not worrying about what others think
- Optimism

Low Self-Esteem: Those with low self-esteem tend to view themselves negatively, doubt their abilities, and are more critical of themselves. They are more susceptible to experiencing feelings of worthlessness, depression, and anxiety.

- Lack of confidence
- Want to be/look like someone else
- Always worrying about what others might think
- Pessimism



Having a balanced self-esteem is crucial for mental well-being. While high self-esteem is generally beneficial, overly inflated self-esteem can lead to [narcissism](#). On the other hand, chronically low self-esteem can contribute to a host of psychological issues, including depression and anxiety.

Measurement

There are several ways of measuring self-esteem. For example, [Harrill Self-Esteem Inventory](#) is a questionnaire comprising 15 statements about a range of interests.

Another example is the [Thematic Apperception Test \(TAT\)](#), which is a neutral cartoon given to the participant, who then has to devise a story about what's going on.

rgyle (2008) believes 4 major factors influence self-esteem.

1. The Reaction of Others

If people admire us, flatter us, seek out our company, listen attentively and agree with us, we tend to develop a positive self-image.

If they avoid, neglect, and tell us things about ourselves that we don't want to hear, we develop a negative self-image.

2. Comparison with Others

If the people we compare ourselves with (our reference group) appear to be more successful, happier, richer, and better looking than ourselves, we tend to develop a negative self-image, BUT if they are less successful than us, our image will be positive.

3. Social Roles

Some social roles carry prestige, e.g., doctor, airline pilot, TV presenter, and premiership footballer, and this promotes self-esteem.

Other roles carry a stigma. E.g., a prisoner, mental hospital patient, refuse collector, or unemployed person.

4. Identification

Roles aren't just "out there." They also become part of our personality, i.e., we identify with the positions we occupy, the roles we play, and the groups we belong to.

But just as important as all these factors are the influence of our parents! (See Coopersmith's research.)

3. Ideal Self

The ideal self can be understood as the self we would want to be or would like to be. It is believed as the individual's true self. It is the desired image of the individual. This includes the vision of the individual. It remains a motivation for individuals to empower and progress towards their goals and aspirations.

The ideal self is important for an individual as it gives the individual a good direction and map towards moving forward. There would be many things or aspects that would remain as blocks or hurdles in moving further. In times like that, the ideal self would remain a key role in pursuing further. The ideal self and its psychological aspects can lead to the pursuit of having an influence or impact on the individual's mental health and well-being. This can simply be said as what one wishes to be.

1. **Comparison with Real Self:** The ideal self stands in contrast to the "real self," which represents how a person currently sees themselves. The gap between these two concepts can influence self-esteem. A smaller gap can lead to higher self-esteem, while a larger gap can result in feelings of dissatisfaction or inadequacy.
2. **Dynamic Nature:** The ideal self is not static; it evolves based on life experiences, societal influences, personal aspirations, and changing values.
3. **Motivation:** The ideal self can serve as a motivational force, pushing individuals to pursue personal growth, learn new skills, and strive for self-improvement.
4. **Potential Pitfalls:** While the ideal self can be a source of inspiration, an unattainable or overly perfectionistic ideal self can lead to disappointment, low self-esteem, and mental distress.

Components Of Self-Concept

The influential American psychologist Carl Rogers was the first to discuss the components of self-concept in 1959. He wrote about three major components:

1. Self-Image

It's how we see ourselves. Our self-image is a combination of different attributes.
(<https://valorhealthcare.com/>)

- **Our Personality Traits (For Example, Introverted, Kind)**
- **Our Social Roles (For Example, Friend, Student)**
- **What We Know About Ourselves Physically (For Example, Tall, Short Hair)**

2. Self-Esteem

Self-esteem is the value that we place on ourselves. Our self-esteem often depends on how we evaluate ourselves. In other words, we make personal comparisons and validate how others respond to us. For example, when our managers respond favorably to our achievements, we are encouraged by our performance and our self-esteem grows.

3. Ideal Self

This is centered on how we wish we could be. For example, if our goal is to lead a large team someday, we create an ideal self and make a checklist of goals we want to work towards. We may direct all our efforts towards achieving that ideal version for ourselves.

Formation Of Self Concept

The formation of self-concept begins during early childhood. It continues to develop and evolve throughout our life. Our self-concept can affect various aspects of our lives, including our careers. Most theories suggest that there's a strong relationship between self-concept and our motivation levels at work.

In an organization, people take on projects, work towards different goals and make choices that drive the business. We generally direct our efforts to complete projects and achieve milestones. By accommodating these external changes, we make room for personal growth. It can be said that our workplace behavior is tied to our view about ourselves—who we are and what we want to achieve.

Harappa Education's Discovering Purpose course will teach you to envision your best possible future self. The Elements of Purpose framework will help you learn about the three crucial parameters necessary to identify your life goals.

Developing A Healthy Self-Concept

It's important to remember that the formation of self-concept is a continuous pursuit. When we put some effort into boosting our self-evaluation, our self-concept adjusts accordingly.

Here Are Some Ways To Develop A Healthy Self-Concept:

1. Look Within

We can start by looking at our inner selves, our belief systems and daily thoughts. If we feel that our 'real' self (who we are) is vastly different from our 'ideal' self (who we want to be), we should invest time and effort to address the difference. We can make adjustments by setting realistic expectations.

2. Check Non-Verbal Cues

Our bodies and minds are connected. Sometimes, what we feel may reflect in our body language. However, there are times when we can redirect our self-concept through our physical movements. For example, some of us walk confidently to feel confident about ourselves.

3. Make Important Choices

Lifestyles and habits impact our self-concept to a large extent. It's one of the factors that determine how we may reach our ideal selves. For example, some of us make it a habit to sleep on time and wake up on time to remain productive throughout the day.

Other concepts about self

Self presentation



Self-Presentation Definition

Self-presentation refers to how people attempt to present themselves to control or shape how others (called the audience) view them. It involves expressing oneself and behaving in ways that create a desired impression. Self-presentation is part of a broader set of behaviors called impression management. Impression management refers to the controlled presentation of information about all sorts of things, including information about other people or events. Self-presentation refers specifically to information about the self.

Self-Presentation History and Modern Usage

Early work on impression management focused on its manipulative, inauthentic uses that might typify a used car salesperson who lies to sell a car, or someone at a job interview who embellishes accomplishments to get a job. However, researchers now think of self-presentation more broadly as a pervasive aspect of life. Although some aspects of self-presentation are deliberate and effortful (and at times deceitful), other aspects are automatic and done with little or no conscious thought. For example, a woman may interact with many people during the day and may make different impressions on each person. When she starts her day at her apartment, she chats with her roommates and cleans up after breakfast, thereby presenting the image of being a good friend and responsible roommate. During classes, she responds to her professor's questions and carefully takes notes, presenting the image of being a good student. Later that day, she calls her parents and tells them about her classes and other activities (although likely leaving out information about some

activities), presenting the image of being a loving and responsible daughter. That night, she might go to a party or dancing with friends, presenting the image of being fun and easygoing. Although some aspects of these self-presentations may be deliberate and conscious, other aspects are not. For example, chatting with her roommates and cleaning up after breakfast may be habitual behaviors that are done with little conscious thought. Likewise, she may automatically hold the door open for an acquaintance or buy a cup of coffee for a friend. These behaviors, although perhaps not done consciously or with self-presentation in mind, nevertheless convey an image of the self to others.

Although people have the ability to present images that are false, self-presentations are often genuine; they reflect an attempt by the person to have others perceive him or her accurately, or at least consistent with how the person perceives himself or herself. Self-presentations can vary as a function of the audience; people present different aspects of themselves to different audiences or under different conditions. A man likely presents different aspects of himself to his close friends than he does to his elderly grandmother, and a woman may present a different image to her spouse than she does to her employer. This is not to say that these different images are false. Rather, they represent different aspects of the self. The self is much like a gem with multiple facets. The gem likely appears differently depending on the angle at which it is viewed. However, the various appearances are all genuine. Even if people present a self-image that they know to be false, they may begin to internalize the self-image and thereby eventually come to believe the self-pres

entation. For example, a man may initially present an image of being a good student without believing it to be genuine, but after attending all his classes for several weeks, visiting the professor during office hours, and asking questions during class, he may come to see himself as truly being a good student. This internalization process is most likely to occur when people make a public commitment to the self-image, when the behavior is at least somewhat consistent with their self-image, and when they receive positive feedback or other rewards for presenting the self-image.

Self-presentation is often directed to external audiences such as friends, lovers, employers, teachers, children, and even strangers. Self-presentation is more likely to be conscious when the presenter depends on the audience for some reward, expects to interact with the audience in the future, wants something from the audience, or values the audience's approval. Yet self-presentation extends beyond audiences that are physically present to imagined audiences, and these imagined audiences can have distinct effects on behavior. A young man at a party might suddenly think about his parents and change his behavior from rambunctious to reserved. People sometimes even make self-presentations only for themselves. For instance, people want to claim certain identities, such as being fun, intelligent, kind, moral, and they may behave in line with these identities even in private.

Self-Presentation Goals

Self-presentation is inherently goal-directed; people present certain images because they benefit from the images in some way. The most obvious benefits are interpersonal, arising from getting others to do what one wants. A job candidate may convey an image of being hardworking and dependable to get a job; a salesperson may convey an image of being trustworthy and honest to achieve a sale. People may also benefit from their self-presentations by gaining respect, power, liking, or other desirable social rewards. Finally, people make certain impressions on others to maintain a sense of who they are, or their self-concept. For example, a man who wants to think of himself as a voracious reader might join a book club or volunteer at a library, or a woman who wishes to perceive herself as generous may contribute lavishly to a charitable

cause. Even when there are few or no obvious benefits of a particular self-presentation, people may simply present an image that is consistent with the way they like to think about themselves, or at least the way they are accustomed to thinking about themselves.

Much of self-presentation is directed toward achieving one of two desirable images. First, people want to appear likeable. People like others who are attractive, interesting, and fun to be with. Thus, a sizable proportion of self-presentation revolves around developing, maintaining, and enhancing appearance and conveying and emphasizing characteristics that others desire, admire, and enjoy. Second, people want to appear competent. People like others who are skilled and able, and thus another sizable proportion of self-presentation revolves around conveying an image of competence. Yet, self-presentation is not so much about presenting desirable images as it is about presenting desired images, and some desired images are not necessarily desirable. For example, schoolyard bullies may present an image of being dangerous or intimidating to gain or maintain power over others. Some people present themselves as weak or infirmed (or exaggerate their weaknesses) to gain help from others. For instance, a member of a group project may display incompetence in the hope that other members will do more of the work, or a child may exaggerate illness to avoid going to school.

Self-Presentation Avenues

People self-present in a variety of ways. Perhaps most obviously, people self-present in what they say. These verbalizations can be direct claims of a particular image, such as when a person claims to be altruistic. They also can be indirect, such as when a person discloses personal behaviors or standards (e.g., “I volunteer at a hospital”). Other verbal presentations emerge when people express attitudes or beliefs. Divulging that one enjoys backpacking through Europe conveys the image that one is a world-traveler. Second, people self-present nonverbally in their physical appearance, body language, and other behavior. Smiling, eye contact, and nods of agreement can convey a wealth of information. Third, people self-present through the props they surround themselves with and through their associations. Driving an expensive car or flying first class conveys an image of having wealth, whereas an array of diplomas and certificates on one’s office walls conveys an image of education and expertise. Likewise, people judge others based on their associations. For example, being in the company of politicians or movie stars conveys an image of importance, and not surprisingly, many people display photographs of themselves with famous people. In a similar vein, high school students concerned with their status are often careful about which classmates they are seen and not seen with publicly. Being seen by others in the company of someone from a member of a disreputable group can raise questions about one’s own social standing.

Self-Presentation Pitfalls

Self-presentation is most successful when the image presented is consistent with what the audience thinks or knows to be true. The more the image presented differs from the image believed or anticipated by the audience, the less willing the audience will be to accept the image. For example, the lower a student’s grade is on the first exam, the more difficulty he or she will have in convincing a professor that he or she will earn an A on the next exam. Self-presentations are constrained by audience knowledge. The more the audience knows about a person, the less freedom the person has in claiming a particular identity. An audience that knows very little about a person will be more accepting of whatever identity the person conveys, whereas an audience that knows a great deal about a person will be less accepting.

People engaging in self-presentation sometimes encounter difficulties that undermine their ability to convey a desired image. First, people occasionally encounter the multiple audience problem, in which they must simultaneously present two conflicting images. For example, a student while walking with friends who

know only her rebellious, impetuous side may run into her professor who knows only her serious, conscientious side. The student faces the dilemma of conveying the conflicting images of rebellious friend and serious student. When both audiences are present, the student must try to behave in a way that is consistent with how her friends view her, but also in a way that is consistent with how her professor views her. Second, people occasionally encounter challenges to their self-presentations. The audience may not believe the image the person presents. Challenges are most likely to arise when people are managing impressions through self-descriptions and the self-descriptions are inconsistent with other evidence. For example, a man who claims to be good driver faces a self-presentational dilemma if he is ticketed or gets in an automobile accident. Third, self-presentations can fail when people lack the cognitive resources to present effectively because, for example, they are tired, anxious, or distracted. For instance, a woman may yawn uncontrollably or reflexively check her watch while talking to a boring classmate, unintentionally conveying an image of disinterest.

Some of the most important images for people to convey are also the hardest. As noted earlier, among the most important images people want to communicate are likeability and competence. Perhaps because these images are so important and are often rewarded, audiences may be skeptical of accepting direct claims of likeability and competence from presenters, thinking that the person is seeking personal gain. Thus, people must resort to indirect routes to create these images, and the indirect routes can be misinterpreted. For example, the student who sits in the front row of the class and asks a lot of questions may be trying to project an image of being a competent student but may be perceived negatively as a teacher's pet by fellow students.

Finally, there is a dark side to self-presentation. In some instances, the priority people place on their appearances or images can threaten their health. People who excessively tan are putting a higher priority on their appearance (e.g., being tan) than on their health (e.g., taking precautions to avoid skin cancer). Similarly, although condoms help protect against sexually transmitted diseases and unwanted pregnancy, self-presentational concerns may dissuade partners or potential partners from discussing, carrying, or using condoms. Women may fear that carrying condoms makes them seem promiscuous or easy, whereas men may fear that carrying condoms makes them seem presumptuous, as if they are expecting to have sex. Self-presentational concerns may also influence interactions with health care providers and may lead people to delay or avoid embarrassing medical tests and procedures or treatments for conditions that are embarrassing. For example, people may be reluctant to seek tests or treatment for sexually transmitted diseases, loss of bladder control, mental disorders, mental decline, or other conditions associated with weakness or incompetence. Finally, concerns with social acceptance may prompt young people to engage in risky behaviors such as excessive alcohol consumption, sexual promiscuity, or juvenile delinquency.

Self-Awareness

Self-awareness is often defined in terms of an ability to engage in reflective awareness. According to most theorists, this requires certain types of cognitive abilities. Even in its most primitive form (visual self-recognition and the ability to recognize oneself in a mirror), self-awareness appears to be restricted to a small subset of animals including humans, chimpanzees, orangutans, and dolphins. In humans, this ability is not present at birth and only begins to appear around 12 to 18 months of age. Furthermore, there appears to be some support for George Herbert Mead's claim that development of this ability requires a social rearing history in which the individual comes to recognize that he or she is distinct from others.

Beyond an ability to be reflectively aware of oneself, self-awareness is often associated with executive processes essential to self-regulation. Thus, the self-aware individual is often viewed as more controlled

and intentional in his or her actions. Within social psychology, self-awareness is often associated with a theory of objective self-awareness by Shelley Duval and Robert Wicklund. According to this theory, situational cues that remind individuals of themselves (e.g., mirrors and video cameras) lead to attention focused on the self and away from the environment. The result is a self-aware state in which individuals are proposed to compare their current selves with ideal self-standards. Because the current or actual self is usually found to be lacking when compared with these standards, Duval and Wicklund proposed that self-awareness creates a negative emotional reaction. This negative affect then motivates the individual either (a) to regulate his or her behavior with respect to the standard in an effort to reduce the discrepancy, or (b) to avoid the self-aware state.

Although this theory has yielded a great deal of research in support of its basic tenets, several researchers noted that self-awareness inducing stimuli often motivate self-regulation without inducing self-criticism and negative affect. Charles Carver and Michael Scheier proposed an alternative theory of self-awareness that retained some features of the Duval and Wicklund model (e.g., self-focused attention), but argued that the comparison of the current self with an ideal standard is itself sufficient to motivate behavior without creating negative affect. Their model of self-awareness was inspired by other cybernetic models of behavior. Jay G. Hull and Alan Levy proposed a more drastic departure from the original Duval and Wicklund model. According to Hull and Levy, self-awareness inducing stimuli essentially act as self-symbolic primes that activate self-knowledge and cause the individual to process situations as personally relevant. Behavior follows as a consequence of focusing on the self-relevant aspects of the environment (as opposed to focusing inward and evaluating self).

Although social psychologists are typically interested in situationally manipulated self-awareness, personality researchers are interested in individual differences in tendency to become self-aware. To measure such differences, Alan Fenigstein, Michael Scheier, and Arnold Buss created the Self-Consciousness Scale. This personality inventory has three subscales: private self-consciousness, public self-consciousness, and social anxiety. Private self-consciousness focuses on the internal experience of self-awareness. It is measured with items such as "I'm always trying to figure myself out," "I reflect about myself a lot," and "I'm alert to changes in my mood." Public self-consciousness focuses on the self-presentational motives sometimes associated with self-awareness and is measured with items such as "I'm concerned about the way I present myself," "I'm concerned about what other people think of me," and "I'm usually aware of my appearance." Social anxiety focuses on negative emotions sometimes associated with being the focus of attention of others and is measured with items such as "I get embarrassed very easily," "I feel anxious when I speak in front of a group," and "Large groups make me nervous." Although the social anxiety subscale captures the colloquial understanding of what it means to be self-conscious, the private and public self-consciousness scales assess individual differences in the psychological processes most often theorized to be associated with the self-aware state.

Given that both public and private self-consciousness measures focus on self, it is not surprising that they tend to be modestly correlated. Similarly, both public self-consciousness and social anxiety tend to be modestly correlated. Private self-consciousness tends not to be correlated with social anxiety. Recently, some researchers have argued that private self-consciousness is itself associated with two subcomponents: internal state awareness characterized by items such as "I am alert to changes in my mood," and reflectiveness characterized by items such as "I reflect about myself a lot." This issue has yet to be resolved.

With respect to individual differences in self-regulation, the components of the Self-Consciousness Scale are often compared with those of the Self-Monitoring Scale introduced by Mark Snyder.

Individuals high in self-monitoring are motivated by self-presentational concerns, whereas individuals low in self-monitoring are motivated by personal concerns. Perhaps the best way to think about the relation of these individual differences is that high self-monitors are both high in public self-consciousness and low in private self-consciousness. Conversely, low self-monitors are both low in public self-consciousness and high in private self-consciousness.

The effects of individual differences in private self-consciousness have often been found to parallel the effects of situational manipulations of self-awareness (e.g., the presence or absence of a mirror). Similarly, the effects of individual differences in public self-consciousness have often been found to parallel the effects of situational manipulations that remind the individual of their appearance to others (e.g., video cameras). As a consequence, researchers often distinguish between situational manipulations of private and public self-awareness along the same lines that they distinguish individual differences of private and public self-consciousness.

Research has regularly demonstrated that both situational manipulations of self-awareness and individual differences in self-consciousness are associated with increased self-regulation. Manipulations of private self-awareness and individual differences in private self-consciousness have been associated with increased attitude-behavior consistency, increased emotional reactivity to success and failure feedback, and increased self-regulation with respect to standards of appropriate conduct (e.g., increased helping when helping is defined as situationally appropriate, and decreased aggression when aggression is defined as situationally inappropriate). Private self-awareness has also been associated with an increased motivation to avoid self-awareness when it is personally painful (e.g., following failure). Indeed, evidence shows that the latter motivation to avoid self-awareness can lead individuals to consume drugs such as alcohol that can lower self-awareness.

Manipulations of public self-awareness and individual differences in public self-consciousness have been associated with increased self-presentation and impression management. For example, individuals high in public self-consciousness demonstrate a greater emphasis on social rather than personal identities, a concern over body image (body weight, clothing, makeup use), and an increased concern with the perspective of others. Although this focus on self-presentational concerns can be useful in gaining the approval of others, it can also lead to somewhat self-destructive impression management strategies (e.g., increased self-handicapping) and even paranoia regarding others' intentions.

Whereas most research on this topic has investigated the effects of manipulations that heighten self-awareness, some research has examined manipulations that lower self-awareness. In addition to alcohol use mentioned previously, these include deindividuation manipulations that render the individual indistinguishable from others (e.g., through anonymity, being in a crowd, darkness, or wearing masks). Such manipulations typically increase disinhibited behavior that does not conform to social and personal norms. One popular account of how this occurs is that deindividuation manipulations lower self-awareness. Paralleling the previous arguments, researchers have distinguished both public and private components of the deindividuated experience. Situations that foster anonymity are thought to reduce aspects of public self-awareness whereas situations that reduce the individual's ability to distinguish themselves from others are thought to reduce aspects of private self-awareness.

Self-Efficacy

Definition

Self-efficacy is defined as people's beliefs in their capabilities to produce desired effects by their own actions. Self-efficacy theory maintains that self-efficacy beliefs are the most important determinants of the behaviors people choose to engage in and how much they persevere in their efforts in the face of obstacles and challenges. Self-efficacy theory also maintains that these self-efficacy beliefs play a crucial role in psychological adjustment, psychological problems, and physical health, as well as in professionally guided and self-guided behavioral change strategies.

Since the publication of Albert Bandura's 1977 Psychological Review article titled "Self-Efficacy: Toward a Unifying Theory of Behavior Change," the term self-efficacy has become ubiquitous in psychology and related fields. Hundreds of articles on every imaginable aspect of self-efficacy have appeared in journals devoted to psychology, sociology, kinesiology, public health, medicine, nursing, and other fields. This article addresses three basic questions: What are self-efficacy beliefs? Where do they come from? Why are they important?

What Are Self-Efficacy Beliefs?

One of the best ways to get a clear sense of how self-efficacy is defined and measured is to distinguish it from related concepts. Self-efficacy is not perceived skill; it is what one believes one can do with one's skills under certain conditions. Self-efficacy beliefs are not simply predictions about behavior. Self-efficacy is concerned not with that one believes one will do but with what one believes one can do. Self-efficacy is not an intention to behave or an intention to attain a particular goal. An intention is what one says one will probably do, and research has shown that intentions are influenced by several factors, including, but not limited to, self-efficacy beliefs. A self-efficacy belief is not the same as a goal but is a belief about one's ability to do what it takes to achieve one's own goals. Self-efficacy is not self-esteem. Self-esteem is what one generally believes about oneself, and how one generally feels about what one believes about oneself. Self-efficacy beliefs are specific beliefs about exercising specific abilities in specific domains. Self-efficacy is not a motive, drive, or need for control. One can have a strong need for control in a particular domain but still hold weak beliefs about one's self-efficacy for that domain. Self-efficacy beliefs are not outcome expectancies (or behavior-outcome expectancies). An outcome expectancy is one's belief that a specific behavior may lead to a specific outcome in a specific situation. A self-efficacy belief, simply put, is one's belief that one can perform the behavior that produces the outcome. Self-efficacy is not a personality trait but, rather, beliefs about one's own ability to coordinate skills and abilities to attain desired goals in particular domains and circumstances. Self-efficacy beliefs can generalize from one situation to another, but specific self-efficacy beliefs are not caused by a personality trait called general self-efficacy.

Where Do Self-Efficacy Beliefs Come From?

Self-efficacy beliefs develop over time and through experience. The development of such beliefs begins in infancy and continues throughout life. The early development of self-efficacy is influenced primarily by two interacting factors: the development of the capacity for symbolic thought, particularly the capacity for understanding cause-effect relationships, and the capacity for self-observation and self-reflection. The development of a sense of personal agency begins in infancy and moves from the perception of the causal relationship between events to an understanding that actions produce results, to the recognition that one can

produce actions that cause results. Children must learn that one event can cause another event, that they are separate from other things and people, and that they can be the origin of actions that effect their environments. As children's understanding of language increases, so does their capacity for symbolic thought and, therefore, their capacity for self-awareness and a sense of personal agency.

Second, the development of self-efficacy beliefs is influenced by the responsiveness of environments, especially social environments, to the infant or child's attempt at manipulation and control. Environments that are responsive to the child's actions facilitate the development of self-efficacy beliefs, whereas nonresponsive environments retard this development. Parents can facilitate or hinder the development of this sense of agency by their responses to the infant or child's actions and by encouraging and enabling the child to explore and master his or her environment.

Self-efficacy beliefs and a sense of agency continue to develop throughout the life span as people continually integrate information from five primary sources, presented here in roughly their descending order of importance in shaping self-efficacy beliefs. People's own performance experiences—their own attempts to control their environments—are the most powerful source of self-efficacy information. Successful attempts at control that one attributes to one's own efforts will strengthen self-efficacy for that behavior or domain. Perceptions of failure at control attempts usually diminish self-efficacy. Self-efficacy beliefs are influenced also by observations of the behavior of others and the consequences of those behaviors—referred to as vicarious experiences. People use this information to form expectancies about their own behavior and its consequences. People also can influence self-efficacy beliefs by imagining themselves or others behaving effectively or ineffectively in hypothetical situations. Self-efficacy beliefs can be influenced by verbal persuasion—what others say to a person about what they believe the person can or cannot do. The potency of verbal persuasion as a source of self-efficacy expectancies will be influenced by such factors as the expertness, trustworthiness, and attractiveness of the source. Physiological and emotional states influence self-efficacy when a person learns to associate poor performance or perceived failure with aversive physiological arousal and success with pleasant feeling states. In activities involving strength and stamina, such as exercise and athletic performances, perceived self-efficacy is influenced by such experiences as fatigue and pain.

Why Are Self-Efficacy Beliefs Important?

Self-efficacy beliefs influence everyday behavior in multiple and powerful ways. Most philosophers and psychological theorists agree that a sense of control over one's behavior, one's environment, and one's own thoughts and feelings is essential for happiness and a sense of well-being. Feelings of loss of control are common among people who seek the help of psychotherapists and counselors. Self-efficacy beliefs play a major role in several common psychological problems, as well as in successful interventions for these problems. Low self-efficacy expectancies are an important feature of depression. Depressed people usually believe they are less capable than are other people of behaving effectively in many important areas of life. Dysfunctional anxiety and avoidant behavior are often the direct result of low self-efficacy expectancies for managing threatening situations. Self-efficacy beliefs play a powerful role in attempts to overcome substance abuse problems and eating disorders. For each of these problems, enhancing self-efficacy for overcoming the problem and for implementing self-control strategies in specific challenging situations is essential to the success of therapeutic interventions.

Self-efficacy beliefs influence physical health in two ways. First, they influence the adoption of healthy behaviors, the cessation of unhealthy behaviors, and the maintenance of behavioral changes in the face of challenge and difficulty. All the major psychological theories of health behavior, such as protection motivation theory, the health belief model, and the theory of reasoned action/planned behavior include self-

efficacy as a key component. In addition, enhancing self-efficacy beliefs is crucial to successful change and maintenance of virtually every behavior crucial to health, including exercise, diet, stress management, safe sex, smoking cessation, overcoming alcohol abuse, compliance with treatment and prevention regimens, and disease detection behaviors such as breast self-examinations.

Second, self-efficacy beliefs influence a number of biological processes that, in turn, influence health and disease. Self-efficacy beliefs affect the body's physiological responses to stress, including the immune system. Lack of perceived control over environmental demands can increase susceptibility to infections and hasten the progression of disease. Self-efficacy beliefs also influence the activation of catecholamines, a family of neurotransmitters important to the management of stress and perceived threat, along with the endogenous painkillers referred to as endorphins.

Self-efficacy beliefs are also crucial to successful self-regulation. Self-regulation depends on three interacting components: goals or standards of performance, self-evaluative reactions to performance, and self-efficacy beliefs. Goals are essential to self-regulation because people attempt to regulate their actions, thoughts, and emotions to achieve desired outcomes. Self-evaluative reactions are important in self-regulation because people's beliefs about the progress they are making (or not making) toward their goals are major determinants of their emotional reactions during goal-directed activity. These emotional reactions, in turn, can enhance or disrupt self-regulation. Self-efficacy beliefs influence self-regulation in several ways. First, self-efficacy influences the goals people set. The higher people's self-efficacy in a specific achievement domain, the loftier will be the goals that they set for themselves in that domain. Second, self-efficacy beliefs influence people's choice of goal-directed activities, expenditure of effort, persistence in the face of challenge and obstacles, and reactions to perceived discrepancies between goals and current performance. Strong self-efficacy beliefs make people more resistant to the disruptions in self-regulation that can result from difficulties and setbacks. As a result, strong self-efficacy beliefs lead people to persevere under difficult and challenging circumstances. Perseverance usually produces desired results, and this success then strengthens self-efficacy beliefs. Third, self-efficacy for solving problems and making decisions influences the efficiency and effectiveness of problem solving and decision making. When faced with complex decisions, people who have confidence in their abilities to solve problems use their cognitive resources more effectively than do those people who doubt their cognitive skills. Such self-efficacy usually leads to better solutions and greater achievement.

Self-efficacy beliefs are crucial to the success of psychotherapy and other interventions for psychological problems. Different interventions, or different components of an intervention, may be equally effective because they equally enhance self-efficacy beliefs for crucial behavioral and cognitive skills. Self-efficacy theory emphasizes the importance of arranging experiences designed to increase the person's sense of self-efficacy for specific behaviors in specific problematic and challenging situations. Self-efficacy theory suggests that formal interventions should not simply resolve specific problems, but should provide people with the skills and sense of self-efficacy for solving problems themselves.

The notion of self-efficacy can also be extended from the individual to the group through the concept of collective efficacy—the extent to which members of a group or organization believe that they can work together effectively to accomplish shared goals. Collective efficacy has been found to be important in several domains. The more efficacious that spouses feel about their shared ability to accomplish important shared goals, the more satisfied they are with their marriages. The collective efficacy of an athletic team can be raised or lowered by false feedback about ability and can subsequently influence its success in competitions. The individual and collective efficacy of teachers for effective instruction seems to affect the academic achievement of school children. The effectiveness of work teams and group brainstorming also

seems to be related to a collective sense of efficacy. Researchers also are beginning to understand the origins of collective efficacy for social and political change

What are self-conscious emotions?

Self-conscious emotions are those affected by how we see ourselves and how we think others perceive us. They include emotions like pride, jealousy, and embarrassment.

Self-consciousness and self-awareness are sometimes healthy signs of emotional maturity. They can help you fit in and function within a community. Feeling guilty after saying something hurtful is often perceived as showing good character. Feeling remorse after making a mistake may help patch up relationships. Positive self-conscious emotions and negative self-conscious emotions can be healthy and powerful motivators.

Excessive self-conscious emotions can be extremely unhealthy. They may worsen symptoms from conditions like anxiety, depression, and borderline personality disorder. They can also cause social anxiety and isolation.

What are the symptoms of self-conscious emotions?

Having self-conscious emotions in moderate amounts is healthy. Having overwhelming self-conscious emotions isn't.

Symptoms of healthy self-conscious emotions include:

- having pride in accomplishments
- enjoying engaging in social environments
- apologizing for mistakes and taking responsibility

Symptoms of unhealthy self-conscious emotions include:

- responding to embarrassment with anger and hostility
- avoiding social experiences
- placing blame on others for one's mistakes
- feeling responsible for wrongs made against yourself
- having low self-esteem
- experiencing agitation, anxiety, depression, or nervousness

What causes self-conscious emotions?

Self-conscious emotions develop in relation to an understanding of rules, standards, and goals. Young children start to form a sense of self at around 18 months old. This is when self-conscious emotions start developing. Many children have a full range of self-conscious emotions by the age of 3.

Adolescents are particularly prone to high levels of self-consciousness. At this age, children are experiencing significant social pressure for the first time.

What are the risk factors of self-conscious emotions?

Low self-esteem can cause unhealthy self-conscious emotions. You may dwell on negative conscious emotions as a result of mental health conditions. These conditions may include:

- anxiety
- depression
- borderline personality disorder (BPD)
- obsessive-compulsive disorder

What are the benefits of self-conscious emotions?

Healthy self-conscious emotions have many benefits. Pride often drives people to work hard for accomplishments. Confidence gives us the self-esteem boost we need to take on new challenges. Even negative self-conscious emotions have a positive role in our lives. Jealousy helps us determine what we want most.

Self-consciousness comes from self-awareness. The emotions that come from them help us perceive how we fit into society. Self-awareness helps us improve social functioning. [Violating](#) a group's social rules causes guilt, shame, and embarrassment. While uncomfortable and disconcerting, these emotions can result in social acceptance.

Can self-conscious emotions cause other issues?

Unhealthy self-consciousness can result in social anxiety. This can lead to isolation, which in turn increases the social anxiety further. It may also result in low self-esteem and depression.

Self-conscious emotions can also prevent healing from traumatic events. This is especially true in patients with mental health conditions. One [studyTrusted Source](#) evaluated women who have BPD and had experienced a trauma. Because of their trauma, these women were dealing with feelings of shame, guilt, and embarrassment. These emotions prevented healing and resulted in increased symptoms of BPD.

People may avoid medical care if they feel certain self-conscious emotions. A [studyTrusted Source](#) found that many people experience shame, guilt, and embarrassment when they're seeking screening tests for sexually transmitted diseases. Getting tested and talking to sexual partners both triggered these emotions. These emotions can cause people to delay or avoid getting the treatment they need.

What treatment is available for self-conscious emotions?

There are many ways to treat unhealthy or excessive self-conscious emotions. To promote a more positive self-image and boost self-esteem, you can:

- engage in activities that make you feel good about yourself
- write a list of accomplishments or traits that you're proud of
- combat social anxiety by interacting with people in low-risk activities, such as making small talk with a cashier when buying groceries
- be punctual and keep your commitments, as the discipline this requires can raise self-value
- take responsibility for mistakes, and make amends if necessary
- avoid activities that can cause negative emotions like guilt or shame if you're caught, such as lying or gossiping
- take a deep breath and practice mindfulness if you're dwelling on past events that cause negative emotions

Make an appointment to see a certified counselor or psychologist if these methods don't offer relief from persistent self-consciousness. A counselor can help you determine the cause of unhealthy self-conscious emotions and get you prescriptions to ease anxiety.

Social perception

What is perception

Perception is an individual's recognition & interpretation of sensory information. It also involves how one response to the information.

A person's ability to precisely evaluate and generate judgments about other individuals based on their overall outer appearances as well as verbal & non-verbal communication patterns is known as social perception. It is a process through which an individual seek to understand the other people.

Process of social perception (mechanism)

People use different techniques, methods and ways to know and understand about others in order to get superficial or a deeper understanding about them. Mechanism of social perception involves non-verbal channels of communications, internal & external attributes, as well as impressions and implicit theories about others.

Knowing the other person involves two stages. Understanding the temporary states of others, i.e. their present emotions and feelings.

Understanding the most permanent or lasting characteristics i.e. their motives, intentions or traits.

- **Understanding temporary states:**

Temporary factors such as , fatigue, illness, and drugs can influence individual's social behavior. To understand others' feelings, people try to understand their non-verbal cues like facial expressions, eye contact, posture, and body movement. And these are hard to control and could also reveal real feelings, especially when they are hidden. This is known as 'non-verbal communication', and their efforts to perceive it are often affected by these temporary factors. for effective social interaction it is important to understand these cues clearly and play a crucial role.

- **Basic channels of non-verbal communication:**

emotional state of an individual also influence their behaviour. The basic channels by which such communications take place and there are five basic channels:

1. facial expressions,
2. eye contact,
3. body language,
4. body movements, and
5. touching and proximics.

Theories of social perception

There are multiple theories of social perception. The important ones are:

1. **Attribution Theory:** focuses on how individuals interpret or perceive other people behaviour by attributing it to external or internal factors. External factors like situational factors or chance (luck) while internal are personality traits or abilities.
2. **Social identity theory:** this theory states that individuals classify other people in social groups on the basis of features they have in common, like country, gender, race, or religion. As per this theory, people's way of perception and interactions with others can be influenced by these group characteristics.
3. **Cognitive dissonance theory:** people may change their attitudes or perceptions to match their behaviors in an effort to lessen their suffering. People face the discomfort when there is inconsistency among ideas, attitudes and behavior and this also causes psychological pain.
4. Social comparison theory and stereotype content model are also considered.

Components of social perception

Observation, attribution, integration and confirmation are the key components of social perception.

- **Observation:** it is the basic component which is based on the interaction of three variables – people, situations and behavior. These variables furnish facts that support up one's perception, or conclusion about others.
- **Attribution:** The process of applying data collected by observation to help people perceive and justify the reasons behind their own and other people's actions is known as attribution.
- **Integration:** While quick judgment is formed by seeing persons, situations, or actions, one integrates these tendencies to develop impressions.
- **Confirmation:** To finally verify these impressions, individuals strive to fully understand, find, and produce knowledge in the form of various biases.

Factors that influence social perception

There are so many factors that influence social perception like physical characteristics, attractiveness, authority and recognition, education, social prestige, status in society, etc. People with higher rank are considered more responsible for their deeds than people with lower status in the society. Individuals who feel powerful view others as masters of their own destiny, whereas those who feel weaker perceive other people as subjects of other forces. Social perception is also influenced by prior experiences, interpersonal connections, and trust. Gratitude and intentionality are shaped by need, value, and prior experiences.

The way a person perceived themselves affects how older children are perceived and judged. Those with high rank are seen as having good intentions, and spontaneous acts performed out of love are accepted. Justifiability is determined by how morally or socially acceptable an activity is.

Functions or roles

It enables individuals to form impressions and judgments about other people which are based on various characteristics like their appearance, behavior, as well as social cues. Also help to navigate the complex social situations and better communication skills. This also permits to form judgments about other individuals in regarding their behavior or actions like trustworthiness or competence. The influence social influence of modifying attitudes, customs, and actions due to which there is betterment in communications. It strengthens social identity as well as foster the sense of connectedness and social connection.

Social Cognition

The study of social cognition involves aspects of both cognitive psychology and social psychology.

What is Cognition?

Cognition is a term referring to the mental processes involved in gaining knowledge and comprehension. These cognitive processes include thinking, knowing, remembering, judging, and problem-solving. These are higher-level functions of the brain and encompass language, imagination, perception, and planning.

Definition of Social Cognition

According to American Psychological Association (APA) **Social Cognition is how people perceive, think about, interpret, categorize, and judge their own social behaviors and those of others.**

According to Baron, 'Social Cognition refers to the manner in which we interpret, analyze, remember and use information about social world.'

Nature of Social Cognition

There are two basic ways to make sense of social world around us.

1. **Automatic Thought / Processing**
2. **Controlled Thoughts / Processing**

1. Automatic Thought / Processing in Social Cognition

We often our thinking about the social world proceeds on “automatic”—quickly, effortlessly, and without lots of careful reasoning.

Basic advantages of Automatics Processing in Social Cognition are –

- It need very little or no efforts.
- It can be very efficient.
- It can lead to **satisfactory** judgements (Dijksterhuis & Olden, 2006)

But, It can also lead to major errors in conclusions.

It occur primarily in **the amygdala** (Cunningham, Johnson, Gatenby, Gore, & Banaji, 2003).

For Example –

Heuristics means simple rule of thumb 🖱 which are quick & effortless.

Schemas are mental frameworks that help us to organize social information, and that guide our actions and the processing of information relevant to those contexts.

2. Controlled Thought / Processing in Social Cognition

It occurs when something unexpected happens.

Unexpected events often triggers such careful, systematic, logical effortful thought.

It involve portions of **the prefrontal cortex** especially the medial & ventrolateral prefrontal cortex (Cunningham, Johnson, Gatenby, Gore, & Banaji, 2003).

Recent evidence suggests that automatic and controlled processing may **often occur together**, especially in situations involving some uncertainty (Sherman et al., 2008). The distinction between automatic and controlled processing is indeed real—and very important.

What is schema

schema describes patterns of thinking and behavior that people use to [interpret the world](#).

We use schemas because they allow us to take shortcuts in interpreting the vast amount of information that is available in our environment. Learn more about what a schema is, different types of schemas, their impact, challenges, and more.

History of schemas

Theorist Jean Piaget introduced the term schema, and its use was popularized through his work.

According to his theory of [cognitive development](#), children go through a series of stages of intellectual growth.

In [Piaget's theory](#), a schema is both the category of knowledge as well as the process of acquiring that knowledge. He believed that people are constantly adapting to the environment as they take in new information and learn new things.

Schema Examples

Looking at an example can help you better understand what a schema is. Consider how a young child may first develop a schema for a horse. They know that a horse is large and has hair, four legs, and a tail. So, when the child encounters a cow for the first time, they might initially call it a horse.

After all, the cow fits in with their schema for the characteristics of a horse—it is a large animal that has hair, four legs, and a tail. Once the child is told that this is a different animal called a cow, they will modify their existing schema for a horse and create a new schema for a cow.

Now, let's imagine that the child encounters a miniature horse for the first time and mistakenly identifies it as a dog. The parents explain that the animal is actually a very small type of horse, so the child must modify their existing schema for horses. The child now realizes that while some horses are very large animals, others can be very small.

Through new experiences, existing schemas are modified and new information is learned.

Types of Schemas

While Piaget focused on childhood development, schemas continue to form and change throughout life. Object schemas are just one type of schema that focuses on what an inanimate object is and how it works. People have all types of schemas for all kinds of information, including schemas about people, objects, places, events, and relationships.

For example, most people in industrialized nations have a schema for what a car is. Your overall schema for a car might include subcategories for different types of automobiles such as a compact car, sedan, or sports car.

The four main types of schemas are:¹

- **Person schemas** are focused on specific individuals. For example, your schema for your friend might include information about their appearance, behaviors, personality, and preferences.
- **Social schemas** include general knowledge about how people behave in certain social situations.
- **Self-schemas** are focused on your knowledge about yourself. This can include both what you know about your current self as well as ideas about your idealized or future self.
- **Event schemas** are focused on patterns of behavior that should be followed for certain events. This acts much like a script informing you of what you should do, how you should act, and what you should say in a particular situation.

How Schemas Change

The processes through which schemas are adjusted or changed are known as assimilation and accommodation.

- [In assimilation](#), new information is incorporated into pre-existing schemas.
- [In accommodation](#), existing schemas might be altered or new schemas formed as a person learns new information and has new experiences.

Schemas tend to be easier to change during childhood but can become increasingly rigid and difficult to modify as people grow older. Schemas will often persist, even when people are presented with evidence that contradicts their beliefs.²

In many cases, people will only begin to slowly change their schema when inundated with a continual barrage of evidence pointing to the need to modify it.

How Schemas Affect Learning

Schemas also play a role in education and the learning process. For example:

- **Schemas influence [what we pay attention to](#).** People are more likely to pay attention to things that fit in with their current schemas.
- **Schemas also impact how quickly people learn.** People learn information more readily when it fits in with the existing schemas.
- **Schemas help simplify the world.** Schemas can often make it easier for people to learn about the world around them. New information could be classified and categorized by comparing new experiences to existing schemas.
- **Schemas allow us to think quickly.** Even under conditions when things are rapidly changing and new information is coming in quickly, people do not usually have to spend a great deal of time interpreting it. Because of the existing schemas, people can assimilate this new information quickly and automatically.
- **Schemas can change how we interpret incoming information.** When [learning new information](#) that does not fit with existing schemas, people sometimes distort or alter the new information to make it fit with what they already know.
- **Schemas can be remarkably difficult to change.** People often cling to existing schemas even in the face of contradictory information.

Challenges of Schemas

While the use of schemas to learn, in most situations, occurs automatically or with little effort, sometimes an existing schema can hinder the learning of new information.³ Prejudice is one example of a schema that prevents people from seeing the world as it is and inhibits them from taking in new information.

By holding certain beliefs about a particular group of people, this existing schema may cause people to interpret situations incorrectly. When an event happens that challenges existing beliefs, people may come up with alternative explanations that uphold and support their existing schema instead of adapting or changing their beliefs.

Consider how this might work for gender expectations and stereotypes. Everyone has a schema for what is considered masculine and feminine in their culture. Such schemas can also lead to stereotypes about how we expect men and women to behave and the roles we expect them to fill.

In one interesting study, researchers showed children images that were either consistent with gender expectations (such as a man working on a car and a woman washing dishes), while others saw images that were inconsistent with gender stereotypes (a man washing dishes and a woman fixing a car).⁴

When later asked to remember what they had seen in the images, children who held very stereotypical views of gender were more likely to change the gender of the people they saw in the gender-inconsistent images. For example, if they saw an image of a man washing dishes, they were more likely to remember it as an image of a woman washing dishes.

Social Roles

One major social determinant of human behavior is our social roles. A **social role** is a pattern of behavior that is expected of a person in a given setting or group (Hare, 2003). Each one of us has several social roles. You may be, at the same time, a student, a parent, an aspiring teacher, a son or daughter, a spouse, and a lifeguard. How do these social roles influence your behavior? Social roles are defined by culturally shared knowledge. That is, nearly everyone in a given culture knows what behavior is expected of a person in a given role. For example, what is the social role for a student? If you look around a college classroom you will likely see students engaging in studious behavior, taking notes, listening to the professor, reading the textbook, and sitting quietly at their desks (Figure 1). Of course you may see students deviating from the expected studious behavior such as texting on their phones or using Facebook on their laptops, but in all cases, the students that you observe are attending class—a part of the social role of students.

Social roles, and our related behavior, can vary across different settings. How do you behave when you are engaging in the role of son or daughter and attending a family function? Now imagine how you behave when you are engaged in the role of employee at your workplace. It is very likely that your behavior will be different. Perhaps you are more relaxed and outgoing with your family, making jokes and doing silly things. But at your workplace you might speak more professionally, and although you may be friendly, you are also serious and focused on getting the work completed. These are examples of how our social roles influence and often dictate our behavior to the extent that identity and personality can vary with context .

Scripts

Because of social roles, people tend to know what behavior is expected of them in specific, familiar settings. A **script** is a person's knowledge about the sequence of events expected in a specific setting (Schank & Abelson, 1977). How do you act on the first day of school, when you walk into an elevator, or are at a restaurant? For example, at a restaurant in the United States, if we want the server's attention, we try to make eye contact. In Brazil, you would make the sound "psst" to get the server's attention. You can see the cultural differences in scripts. To an American, saying "psst" to a server might seem rude, yet to a Brazilian, trying to make eye contact might not seem an effective strategy. Scripts are important sources of information to guide behavior in given situations. Can you imagine being in an unfamiliar situation and not having a script for how to behave? This could be uncomfortable and confusing. How could you find out about social norms in an unfamiliar culture?

Stereotype

By stereotyping, we infer that a person has a whole range of characteristics and abilities that we assume all members of that group have—for example, a "hells angel" biker dressed in leather.

One advantage of a stereotype is that it enables us to respond rapidly to situations because we may have had a similar experience before.

One disadvantage is that it makes us ignore differences between individuals; therefore, we think things about people that might not be true (i.e., make generalizations).

The use of stereotypes is a major way in which we simplify our social world; since they reduce the amount of processing (i.e., thinking), we have to do when we meet a new person.

Stereotypes lead to social categorization, which is one of the reasons for prejudiced attitudes (i.e., “them” and “us” mentality), which leads to in-groups and out-groups.

Positive examples of stereotypes include judges (the phrase “sober as a judge” would suggest this is a stereotype with a very respectable set of characteristics), overweight people (who are often seen as “jolly”), and television newsreaders (usually seen as highly dependable, respectable and impartial). Negative stereotypes seem far more common, however.

Stereotype Threat

A stereotype threat arises when one is in a situation where one has a fear of doing something that would inadvertently confirm a negative stereotype. It is cued by the mere recognition that a negative group stereotype could apply to you in a given situation.

It is important to understand that the person may experience a threat even if he or she does not believe the stereotype.

Steele and Aronson (1995) conducted an experiment involving African American and White college students who took a difficult test using items from an aptitude test (American GRE Verbal exam) under one of two conditions.

In the stereotype threat condition, students were told that their performance on the test would be a good indicator of their underlying intellectual abilities.

In the non-threat condition, they were told that the test was simply a problem-solving exercise and was not diagnostic of ability.

Performance was compared in the two conditions, and results showed that African American participants performed less well than their white counterparts in the stereotype threat condition, but in the non-threat condition, their performance equaled that of their white counterparts.

What are some strategies to challenge and overcome stereotypes?

Some strategies to challenge and overcome stereotypes include increasing awareness and understanding through education and exposure to diverse perspectives, engaging in critical thinking, and questioning assumptions.

Likewise, fostering empathy and open-mindedness, actively seeking out counter-stereotypical information and experiences, promoting positive intergroup contact and dialogue, and advocating for equal representation and inclusive policies.

By consciously challenging our own biases, engaging in constructive conversations, and promoting inclusivity, we can begin to break down stereotypes and work towards a more equitable society.

Can stereotypes influence our behavior and decision-making?

Yes, stereotypes can influence our behavior and decision-making. When we hold stereotypes about certain groups, these beliefs can unconsciously shape our perceptions, attitudes, and actions towards individuals belonging to those groups.

Stereotypes can impact how we interpret information, how we interact with others, and even our hiring and promotion decisions. They can lead to unfair treatment, prejudice, and discrimination.

It is important to be aware of the influence of stereotypes on our behavior and actively challenge and mitigate their effects to promote fairness and equality.

The Meaning of Attributions

Attributions are conscious or unconscious **subjective cognitive conclusions** about the cause of an event or situation. In simple terms, attributions are basically how a person **perceives** a situation or event. In the example of Jenna arriving late for work, her boss attributed her lateness to an **external factor**: heavy traffic. He could have attributed her lateness to an **internal factor** about Jenna: she was late because she didn't get up early enough that morning.

Attributions in Psychology

When we attribute a **cause** to an event, we make a **decision or conclusion** about why something happened. Attributions are a common topic of study in psychology. The psychologist Fritz Heider studied attributions back in the early 1900s, and he developed **the attribution theory** in psychology.

Example

Toby came to school without money for lunch. Toby's friend Lilo attributes Toby's lack of lunch money to forgetting to bring it. Actually, Toby came to school without lunch money because his parents had no money to send with him. If Lilo attributed Toby's lack of lunch money to his family's financial struggles, how would that change Lilo's **attitude** and actions towards Toby?

Attributional Styles

Attributional style varies depending on a person's general **outlook** on life and way of explaining or interpreting life events. Attributional styles are based on the idea that either we control our environment or it controls us. In other words, it is often based on our **locus of control**. People with an **optimistic attributional style** have a generally positive **attitude** toward life events even when things are not going well. People with a **pessimistic attributional style** generally respond negatively to life events and attribute them to forces outside of their control.

Example of Attributions

Attributions impact our behaviors, thoughts, and feelings. They can also impact **motivation** in ourselves and others. Psychologists want to understand better **why and how** we make cognitive attributions and how they contribute to the way we treat others. Types of attributions in psychology include **dispositional attributions, situational attributions, cognitive biases, and perceptual shortcuts**.

Dispositional Attributions

Internal attributions are also known as **dispositional attributions**. Internal attributions occur when someone relates an experience to personal factors, emotions, moods, or personality traits. For example, if someone does well at a cheerleading competition, they may believe it is due to internal attributes and their personal efforts.

Situational Attributions

External attributions are also known as **situational attributions**. External attributions happen when someone considers factors outside themselves. Social factors come into play, such as race, age, location, other people, etc. For example, if someone is late to work, external attributes such as traffic or car accidents might be considered.

Biases and Attributions

Bias is when we favor a particular person, group, thing, or idea. Biases can be either implicit or explicit, meaning they are either unconscious or conscious. **Implicit bias** is unconscious, preconceived outlooks or perspectives influenced by past life experiences. **Prejudice** is an example of a negative implicit bias toward other people, groups, or ideas.

Explicit bias is conscious, preconceived outlooks or perspectives that guide our thoughts and responses. Explicit biases influence how we determine the causes of our behaviors and other people's behaviors. In general, humans attribute the behaviors of other people to internal

factors and behaviors of our own to external factors. When this occurs, it is known as the **fundamental attribution error (FAE)**.

Lucy had a long, hard day at work. When she gets home, her kids are acting crazy and making a mess. She snaps at them and reacts based on her stress level. She feels bad afterward, but she attributes her behavior to external factors like the stress of her day at work. The next day, Lucy visits her friend Mark's house. Mark also has kids, and he snaps at his kids for breaking a toy. Lucy is shocked and attributes Mark's behavior to poor parenting.

Perceptual Shortcuts and Attributions

Shortcuts are often called **perceptual shortcuts** in psychology when considering attributions. These shortcuts are ways that we often look over or miss information that might be vital in understanding if there is an internal or external cause. We use **selective perception** to decide what information to pay attention to and what information to ignore. When we do this, we often use our bias to choose what to pay attention to. The judgment we have based on the shortcuts can lead to attributions surrounding a situation or event.

Group Attributions in Psychology

Group attributions in psychology often relate to in-group and out-group biases. **In-group bias** is the tendency to favor other group members over people who belong to another group. If we are part of a group that believes eating meat is not okay, we may treat others in our group better than we treat those in other groups. We may use perceptual shortcuts to ignore the fact that eating meat has benefits, like added protein and vitamins. **Out-group bias** is the exact opposite: undervaluing those that are not part of your group.

In-group and out-group biases can lead to prejudice and discrimination against others. **Prejudice** is a negative implicit bias that leads to unfair or poor judgments of entire groups of people. **Discrimination** is the **action** side of prejudice. Prejudice is the attribution; discrimination is how we treat people based on our attributions.

Attribution Theory

Attribution theory explains how we perceive the actions of others and form attributions. There are three key factors in attribution theory: **distinctiveness, consensus, and consistency**. **Distinctiveness** is when we closely observe someone's behavior and decide if it is common or uncommon. By observing the behavior and making a decision, we decide if the cause is internal or external.

Antonio sings in the car, in the shower, and in his home. His voice is wonderful so his parents encourage him to try out for the school's talent show. Antonio follows his parents' guidance and tries out. When Antonio stands on stage in front of the judges, he freezes for a few seconds and then moves on with his song. Antonio's voice cracks and he sounds shaky when performing, which is uncommon based on his parent's perception. This performance flaw can be attributed to external factors such as new people and a new environment. The judges who

have never met Antonio before may attribute his performance to poor singing abilities or issues with stage fright.

Consensus is when we make a generalized observation based on what most people do in a group. If most of the group has the same observable behavior or experience, our attribution of the cause of the behavior or experience will likely be external. If the majority display uncommon behavior within the group, our attribution will likely be internal

There are a group of ten employees attending a meeting, and seven of them are vegetarians. Jack, the company CEO, notices that only three people eat meat. Jack attributes the vegetarian employees' food preferences to external factors: it is becoming more popular in society, and they want to fit in with each other. Jack attributes the non-vegetarian food preferences to internal factors: the employees who eat meat are not as earth-conscious or concerned with animal rights. The reverse of Jack's attributions could actually be true, but he attributes caused based on consensus.

Consistency

Consistency is when we observe if the behavior is common or uncommon. If an action or behavior rarely occurs in someone, we might consider it an external cause. If the behavior is recurring, it is most likely internal. Throughout this process, we are able to determine what we believe to be the root of someone's behavior.

Raya watches ballet so she can learn to improve her dance moves. She notices that one of her favorite dancers, Kira, practices 6 days a week. Raya observes consistency in Kira's method, which means it is a common practice for Kira. Raya attributes Kira's behavior to an internal cause: Kira is dedicated and motivated to practice and wants to improve her skills. Actually, Kira's practices are scheduled by her coach and mom, and she participates whether she wants to or not.

Altruism

Altruism is the unselfish concern for other people—doing things simply out of a desire to help, not because you feel obligated to out of duty, loyalty, or religious reasons. It involves acting out of concern for the well-being of other people.

In some cases, these acts of altruism lead people to jeopardize themselves to help others. Such behaviors are often performed unselfishly and without any expectations of reward. Other instances, known as reciprocal altruism, involve taking actions to help others with the expectation that they will offer help in return.¹

How to Stop Being Selfish

Examples of Altruism

Everyday life is filled with small acts of altruism, from holding the door for strangers to giving money to people in need. News stories often focus on grander cases of altruism, such as a man who dives into an icy river to rescue a drowning stranger or a donor who gives thousands of dollars to a local charity.

Some examples of altruism include:

- Doing something to help another person with no expectation of reward
- Forgoing things that may bring personal benefits if they create costs for others
- Helping someone despite personal costs or risks
- Sharing resources even in the face of scarcity
- Showing concern for someone else's well-being

Types of Altruism

Psychologists have identified several different types of altruistic behavior. These include:

- **Genetic altruism:** As the name suggests, this type of altruism involves engaging in altruistic acts that benefit close family members. For example, parents and other family members often engage in acts of sacrifice in order to provide for the needs of family members.
- **Reciprocal altruism:** This type of altruism is based on a mutual give-and-take relationship. It involves helping another person now because they may one day be able to return the favor.
- **Group-selected altruism:** This involves engaging in altruistic acts for people based upon their group affiliation. People might direct their efforts toward helping people who are part of their social group or supporting social causes that benefit a specific group.
- **Pure altruism:** Also known as moral altruism, this form involves helping someone else, even when it is risky, without any reward. It is motivated by internalized values and morals.

What Causes Altruism?

While we may be familiar with altruism, [social psychologists](#) are interested in understanding *why* it occurs.² What inspires these acts of kindness? What motivates people to risk their own lives to save a complete stranger?

Altruism is one aspect of what is known as [prosocial behavior](#). Prosocial behavior refers to any action that benefits other people, no matter what the motive or how the giver benefits from the action.

While all altruistic acts are prosocial, not all prosocial behaviors are completely altruistic. We might help others for a variety of reasons such as guilt, obligation, duty, or even for rewards.

We're not sure why altruism exists, but psychologists have suggested a number of different explanations.

Evolution

Psychologists have long debated whether some people are just born with a natural tendency to help others, a theory that suggests that altruism may be influenced by genetics.

Kin selection is an evolutionary theory that proposes that people are more likely to help those who are blood relatives because it will increase the odds of gene transmission to future generations, thus ensuring the continuation of shared genes.² The more closely the individuals are related, the more likely people are to help.

Prosocial behaviors such as altruism, cooperativeness, and empathy may also have a genetic basis.³

Brain-Based Rewards

Altruism activates reward centers in the [brain](#). Neurobiologists have found that when a person behaves altruistically, the pleasure centers of their brain become more active.

Engaging in compassionate actions activates the areas of the brain associated with the reward system.⁴ The positive feelings created by compassionate actions then reinforce altruistic behaviors.

Environment

Interactions and relationships with others have a major influence on altruistic behavior, and socialization may have a significant impact on altruistic actions in young children.

In one study, children who observed simple reciprocal acts of altruism were far more likely to exhibit altruistic actions. On the other hand, friendly but non-altruistic actions did not inspire the same results.¹

Modeling altruistic actions can be an important way to foster prosocial and compassionate actions in children.

Observing prosocial behavior seems to lead to helping behavior among adults as well (though the extent to which this occurs varies based on factors like gender, culture, and individual context).⁵

Social Norms

Society's rules, norms, and expectations can also influence whether or not people engage in altruistic behavior. The [norm of reciprocity](#), for example, is a social expectation in which we feel pressured to help others if they have already done something for us.¹

For example, if your friend loaned you money for lunch a few weeks ago, you'll probably feel compelled to reciprocate when they ask you if they can borrow \$100. They did something for you, now you feel obligated to do something in return.

Incentives

While the definition of altruism involves doing for others without reward, there may still be cognitive incentives that are not obvious. For example, we might help others to relieve our own distress or because being kind to others upholds our view of ourselves as kind people.⁴ Other cognitive explanations include:

- **Empathy:** People are more likely to engage in altruistic behavior when they feel empathy for the person in distress, a suggestion known as the empathy-altruism hypothesis.⁴ Children also tend to become more altruistic as their sense of empathy develops.
- **Helping relieve negative feelings:** Altruistic acts may help alleviate the negative feelings associated with seeing someone else in distress, an idea referred to as the negative-state relief model. Essentially, seeing another person in trouble causes us to feel upset, distressed, or uncomfortable, but helping them reduces these negative feelings.

[Why Being Good to Others Also Benefits You](#)

Is Being Altruistic Good?

While altruism can have some drawbacks when taken to extremes, it is a positive force that can benefit both you and others. Altruism has a wide range of benefits, like:

- **Better health:** Behaving altruistically can improve physical health in a variety of ways. People who [volunteer](#) have better overall health, and regularly engaging in helping behaviors is linked to a significantly lower mortality.⁶
- **Better mental well-being:** Doing good things for other people can make you feel good about yourself and the world. Research shows that people experience increased happiness after doing good things for other people.⁷
- **Better romantic relationships:** Being kind and compassionate can also lead to a [better relationship](#) with your partner, as kindness is one of the most important qualities that people across all cultures seek in a romantic partner.⁸

In addition to these benefits, engaging in altruism can also help improve [social connections](#) and relationships, which can ultimately play a part in improving health and wellness.

Fostering Altruism

Some people come by altruistic tendencies naturally, but there are things you can do to help foster helpful behaviors in yourself and others. These include:

- **Find inspiration:** Look to inspirational people who engage in altruistic acts. Seeing others work to actively improve the lives of individuals and communities can inspire you to act altruistically in your own life.
- **Practice empathy:** Rather than distancing yourself from others, practice [empathy](#) by building connections and putting a human face on the problems you see. Consider how you would feel in that situation, and think about things that you can do to help make a difference.
- **Set a goal:** Find ways that you can regularly perform random acts of kindness for others. Look around you for people who may need help, or look for ways that you can volunteer in your community. Fix a meal for someone in need, help a friend with a chore, donate during a blood drive, or spend some time volunteering for a local organization.
- **Make it a habit:** Try to keep kindness in the forefront of your thoughts. For example, think about the altruistic acts you've performed, how they might have helped someone, and how you might repeat them going forward. Or, consider performing at least one act of kindness a day, and take some time to reflect on it.

Potential Pitfalls of Altruism

There can be some possible drawbacks and difficulties to altruism, like:

- It can sometimes create risk. People may engage in altruistic acts that can place them in danger.
- It may sometimes lead people to neglect their own health, social, or financial needs in order to care for others.
- While acts of altruism may be done with good intentions, they don't always lead to positive outcomes.
- It may lead people to focus their efforts on one cause while neglecting others.

People who work in helping professions may find themselves emotionally overwhelmed by caring for and helping others. In a more severe example, a person who altruistically adopts animals may shift into

animal [hoarding](#), reaching a point where they can no longer house or care for the animals they have taken in.

Despite these potential problems, altruism is generally a positive force in the world, and it's a skill worth developing.

Aggression

In [psychology](#), aggression refers to a range of behaviors that can result in both physical and psychological harm to yourself, others, or objects in the environment. Aggression centers on hurting another person either physically or mentally.

While we all may feel aggressive on occasion, when aggression becomes pervasive or extreme, it may be a sign of an underlying [mental health condition](#), a substance use disorder, or another medical issue.¹

Aggression can serve a number of different purposes, including:

- Expressing anger or hostility
- Asserting dominance
- [Intimidating](#) or threatening
- Achieving a goal
- Expressing possession
- Responding to fear
- Reacting to pain
- Competing with others

Signs of Aggression

Because aggressive behavior is intended to harm someone who doesn't want to be harmed, it must involve action—simply thinking about harming someone or feeling angry isn't enough, and accidentally harming someone doesn't qualify. Aggressive behaviors can be:²

- **Physical**, like beating, hitting, kicking, or stabbing another person. Damaging property is also a form of physical aggression.
- **Verbal**, which may include mocking, name-calling, and yelling.
- **Relational**, which is intended to harm another person's relationships. This can include spreading rumors and telling lies about someone else.
- **[Passive-aggressive](#)**, like ignoring someone during a social event or offering back-handed compliments. Passive-aggressive behavior is usually intended to *allow* harm to come to someone, rather than causing harm directly.

While we often think of aggression in its physical forms, psychological aggression can also be very damaging. Intimidating or verbally berating another person, for instance, are examples of verbal, mental, and emotional aggression. [Cyberbullying](#) is another form of non-physical aggression that can cause serious harm to others.

[How to Identify Emotional Abuse](#)

Types of Aggression

Psychologists divide aggression into two main types. Both are damaging to those who experience them, whether as the target or the aggressor.

Impulsive Aggression

Also known as affective or reactive aggression, impulsive aggression is characterized by strong emotions. Impulsive aggression, especially when it's caused by anger, triggers the acute threat response system in the brain, involving the [amygdala](#), hypothalamus, and periaqueductal gray.¹

This form of aggression is not planned and often takes place in the heat of the moment. If another car cuts you off in traffic and you begin yelling and berating the other driver, you're experiencing impulsive aggression.

Instrumental Aggression

Also known as predatory aggression, instrumental aggression is marked by behaviors that are intended to achieve a larger goal.¹ Instrumental aggression is often carefully planned and usually exists as a means to an end.

Hurting another person in a robbery is an example of this type of aggression. The aggressor's goal is to obtain money, and harming another individual is the means to achieve that aim.

Causes

We don't know precisely what causes excessive or inappropriate aggression. It's likely that several different factors are involved, including someone's biology, environment, and psychological history.

Biological Factors

There may be genetic and hormonal factors that influence aggression. Imbalances in certain hormones, like testosterone and [cortisol](#), and neurotransmitters, like serotonin and dopamine, may be linked to aggression.³ These imbalances can occur for a number of reasons, including genetics.

Brain structure can also influence aggression. People with structural abnormalities in the amygdala tend to show more aggression than their peers. Changes in other areas of the brain may also contribute to aggressive behavior.³

Environmental Factors

How you were raised may play a role in whether or not you engage in aggressive behavior. People who grow up witnessing aggression may be more likely to believe that violence and hostility are socially acceptable. Experiencing trauma during childhood can also lead to aggressive behavior in adulthood.⁴

[Childhood Trauma and Intermittent Explosive Disorder](#)

Psychologist Albert Bandura's famous [Bobo doll experiment](#) demonstrated that [observational learning](#) can also play a role in how aggression develops. In this experiment, children who watched a video clip where an adult model behaved aggressively toward a Bobo doll were more likely to imitate those actions when given the opportunity.

Psychological Factors

Several mental health conditions can be associated with aggressive behavior, including:

- [Attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder \(ADHD\)](#)⁵
- [Bipolar disorder](#)⁶
- [Borderline personality disorder \(BPD\)](#)⁷
- [Narcissism](#)⁸
- [Post-traumatic stress disorder \(PTSD\)](#)⁹

Epilepsy, [dementia](#), [psychosis](#), substance use disorder, and brain injuries or abnormalities can also influence aggression.¹⁰

Impact of Aggression

[Aggression can affect your health](#) and relationships. Research suggests that there is a link between anger and chronic inflammation, which can cause secondary health problems like cardiovascular issues.¹¹ Anger and aggression are also associated with mental health conditions. However, it isn't clear if unregulated anger *causes* those conditions, or if the conditions themselves make it difficult to manage intense emotions like anger and aggression.¹²

Experiencing aggression at the hands of a partner, friend, or family member also has detrimental effects. People who have been victims of physical or psychological aggression view those experiences as harmful, even when their aggressor doesn't.¹³ These forms of aggression can ultimately lead to the end of the relationship.¹⁴

Unchecked aggression can also make things more difficult at work and strain friendships. That can lead to more [stress](#) and feelings of alienation for the aggressor, which may worsen the problem.

Help With Managing Aggression

If you're experiencing feelings of aggression, you can learn to [manage your anger](#) and cope in a more constructive way. Developing an [anger management plan](#) ahead of time can give you a roadmap to use when your emotions feel out of control. That plan should include ways to reduce your stress levels, like:

- Being mindful of your anger warning signs, like clenching your jaw, a fast pulse, or sweating
- Practicing relaxation techniques like [deep breathing](#), [meditation](#), or [progressive muscle relaxation \(PMR\)](#)
- Engaging with your senses by focusing on things you can see, smell, hear, touch, or taste
- Walking away from the situation
- [Exercising](#) to burn off excess energy
- Reaching out to a trusted friend or family member for [social support](#)
- Distracting yourself with another activity
- [Reframing](#) negative thoughts
- Learning to explore and [accept the emotions](#) underlying the aggression

If someone in your life is behaving aggressively toward you, it's important to protect your own mental health and physical safety. Try to stay calm and avoid escalating the conflict, and walk away if it's safe to do so. If you're facing aggression at the hands of an intimate partner, look out for [warning signs](#) that the relationship is becoming dangerous, and [reach out for help and support](#).

What Are the Five Conflict Resolution Strategies?

Different people use different methods to resolve conflict, and most people have one or more natural, preferred conflict resolution strategies that they use regularly. It is possible to scientifically measure an individual's inclinations toward specific conflict resolution strategies. In this article, we will discuss the five different categories of conflict resolution from the Thomas-Kilmann model, as well as their advantages and disadvantages.

The Thomas-Kilmann Model

The Thomas-Kilmann Model identifies five different approaches to resolving conflict. These approaches include:

1. Avoiding

Someone who uses a strategy of "avoiding" mostly tries to ignore or sidestep the conflict, hoping it will resolve itself or dissipate.

2. Accommodating

Using the strategy of "accommodating" to resolve conflict essentially involves taking steps to satisfy the other party's concerns or demands at the expense of your own needs or desires.

3. Compromising

The strategy of "compromising" involves finding an acceptable resolution that will partly, but not entirely, satisfy the concerns of all parties involved.

4. Competing

Someone who uses the conflict resolution strategy of "competing" tries to satisfy their own desires at the expense of the other parties involved.

5. Collaborating

Using "collaborating" involves finding a solution that entirely satisfies the concerns of all involved parties.

The Thomas-Kilmann model identifies two dimensions people fall into when choosing a conflict resolution strategy: assertiveness and cooperativeness. Assertiveness involves taking action to satisfy your own needs, while cooperativeness involves taking action to satisfy the other's needs.

Each of the conflict resolution strategies above involves different degrees of assertiveness and cooperativeness. For example, while accommodating includes a high degree of cooperativeness and a low degree of assertiveness, competing consists of a low degree of cooperativeness and a high degree of assertiveness.

Choosing the Right Conflict Resolution Method

Even though you may prefer one of the conflict resolution strategies discussed above over the others, all of these strategies can be used effectively in certain situations.

For example, if the issue is minor and won't have lasting consequences, it may be in your best interest to accommodate the other party rather than to try to serve your own needs. However, if the issue is more severe and will impact multiple people, it may make sense to choose a strategy with more assertiveness.

To choose the best conflict resolution method in any given situation, you need to consider several factors, such as:

- How important your desires are.
- The impact on you or others if your desires are not served.
- The consequences of choosing to be more assertive.
- Whether a collaborative or cooperative solution exists.

Improving Your Ability to Resolve Conflict

Being able to choose and apply the best conflict resolution strategy effectively is made possible by developing better [conflict resolution skills](#). Examples of conflict resolution skills that can help you include the ability to:

- Listen effectively.
- Identify specific points of disagreement.
- Express your own needs clearly.
- View conflict as an opportunity for growth.
- Focus on specific issues without generalizing or escalating the situation.

Although you may have a proclivity towards a specific type of conflict resolution, you are not required to use this strategy in every situation. With time and effort, you can learn new conflict resolution skills that improve your ability to negotiate and resolve issues with others. Eventually, you will be able to select and use the [conflict resolution strategy](#) that is best for the situation, as opposed to the one that is most comfortable or familiar.

Group behavior

Definition of Group Behavior

First, let's examine what defines a group. Groups are formed for many different reasons and in many ways. They can be very powerful in that an individual may be able to accomplish more with a group than by oneself.

A **group** is defined as two or more people who interact and share a common identity, belief, purpose, or morals.

Group behavior refers to the actions, thoughts, or feelings of a collection of people or individuals within a group.

Group behavior is often guided by a set of rules or regulations that may not always be the case for every individual within that group.

Group Behavior and Group Identity

Once we identify with a group, we begin to categorize ourselves within an **ingroup** and others in an **outgroup**. The tendency is to form an "us vs them" mentality and view outgroups as homogeneous and favor our ingroup.

Outgroup homogeneity refers to our tendency to see members of our ingroup as individuals and members of an outgroup as the same.

Ingroup favoritism or **ingroup bias** refers to our tendency to assume that people similar to us are like us, favoring ingroup members over outgroup members.

Four Aspects of Group Behavior

There are four aspects of a group's behavior that may be present within a group.

1. **Purpose and Mission:** Individuals within the group share similar beliefs, values, or attitudes resulting in a unified mission or purpose. The group may then develop clear goals or a specific agenda.
2. **Norms:** The group has a clear standard of behavioral norms. These norms are used to evaluate group members. Behavioral norms may be clearly written as rules, or they may be informal. However, group members are always aware of what the behavior norms are.
3. **Cohesion:** How well the group can overcome conflict or other unpleasant experiences. If cohesion is low, the group may struggle to establish control over its members and enforce its behavior norms and rules.
4. **Structure:** Each group has a structure for status and authority. This may be hierarchical or more democratic. There is also a clear dynamic between the leader and the follower.

Types of Group Behavior

Communal labor, joining protests or a march, acting patriotically, and spectating are examples of social situations in which group behavior may occur.

Group Behavior: Communal Labor

Communal labor refers to a group that comes together to accomplish a specific task that benefits the group as a whole. This type of group behavior is usually constructive as cooperation is imperative for the group to accomplish its task. Members of groups that gather for communal labor often have common social interests, aspirations, feelings, and a particular topic.

Joining a Protest or March

Another form of group behavior is when individuals join a protest or march. In this case, individuals come together to protest for or against a cause. A modern-day example of a protest or demonstration is

the one that took place after the murder of George Floyd. Or the Women's March that formed following the inauguration of former President Donald Trump

Acting Patriotically

Groups that have been formed as a result of shared love and pride for their country are acting patriotically. The behavior of groups who have gathered for this purpose is often zealous and committed. Groups acting patriotically can be constructive but can also easily become destructive.

Group Behavior: Spectators

A spectator group behavior refers to gathering a group of people with the shared purpose to participate in or attend an event. Events may include a concert, movie, or sports game.

Culture as a Form of Group Behavior

Culture refers to a group's shared attitudes, ideas, values, traditions, and behaviors passed down from generation to generation.

Humans are social animals capable of learning and adapting their behaviors for survival. Cultures form as the result of this human trait. Through language, humans have been able to preserve innovation throughout history. Even though we differ across cultures, our capacity for culture is the same. Culture enables us to communicate, play, engage in commerce, and live.

As cultures compete for resources, they evolve over time. A Frenchman in the fourteenth century might not fully understand a Frenchman in the twenty-first century. While cultures evolve to survive, the change is not always positive. For example, although the federal government increased the loan amount a student could borrow for their post-secondary degree, it may have allowed colleges to raise their tuition costs. (Bundick & Pollard, 2019). Culture and cultural differences can greatly affect the behavior of groups and individuals within that group.

group Behavior – Examples

Group behavior can occur in everyday situations. Here are some examples:

- Planning/executing cultural festival
- Organizing the clean up of a dirty street corner
- Setting up a community garden
- Black Lives Matter Protests
- March on Washington during the Civil Rights Movement
- Dakota Access Pipeline Protest
- January 6th United States Capitol Attack

Group Behavior in Psychology

Individual behavior differs from group behavior in the first may be influenced by several internal and external factors. Individual behavior may result from genes, mental health, environment, or self-perception.

When group behavior is observed in psychology, the focus is on how groups affect an individual's behavior, [thinking](#), decision-making, or ideas. Psychologists also observe how groups behave as a whole and how groups interact with one another.

Group Polarization

The ways in which a group interacts with other groups and with one another is called [group dynamics](#). **Group polarization** is when a group's beliefs and inclinations are enhanced through group discussion, and decisions are more extreme than an individual's initial inclination.

Group polarization is when a group's beliefs and inclinations are enhanced through group discussion, and decisions are more extreme than an individual's initial inclination.

For example, a class discussion would make students whose prejudice is low become more accepting after discussing racial issues. However, students whose prejudice is high would become less accepting after discussing racial issues. In the real world, we see group polarization occur in politics. After a debate, political groups may become more polarized in their views.

Group polarization often intensifies the "us vs them" mentality. Group members may also behave in more extreme ways than while on their own. While increasing access through the internet can be a powerful tool in connecting people, it can also be a powerful tool in polarizing people's opinions. Conservatives can connect more with other conservative perspectives, and liberals can connect more with other liberal views.

Conformity

In 1955, [Solomon Asch](#) conducted an experiment to test conformity within a group.

Conformity is when a person's behavior changes to match the group's behavior, regardless of their own opinion.

In the experiment, he had a group of people answer a very easy question. However, each group had confederates, people who work for the researcher, who answered the question incorrectly. Then, Asch observed how often the subjects would give the wrong answer. This resulted in the Asch effect, which refers to how the group majority influences an individual's behavior and judgment.

Groupthink

When faced with a decision, groups may reach a consensus due to the desire for harmony. This phenomenon is called groupthink. This consensus, however, may not have been achieved through reason or evaluation.

Groupthink is the phenomenon in which decision-making groups reach a consensus due to the desire for harmony, regardless of any consequences or alternatives.

Groupthink is often fed by **overconfidence**, **conformity**, **group polarization**, and **self-justification**. (Meyer et al., 2009). Throughout history, administrations in the United States have fallen victim to groupthink. For example, social psychologist Irvin Janis (1982) discovered that the Kennedy administration's decision to invade Cuba with Cuban exiles trained by the CIA was likely led by a collective desire to preserve the morale. Leaders opted to ignore their doubts to protect the harmony of the group.

Helping People

Individual behavior can be especially influenced by the presence of others when it comes to helping.

The **bystander effect**, for example, refers to a situation in which people are less likely to offer help if others are around.

This phenomenon can often have negative effects where no one steps up to help because they believe someone else will be there to do it. Or, have you heard of the saying, “Scratch my back, and I’ll scratch yours?” This reflects the reciprocity norm, the idea that individuals within a group expect others to help them if they help others.

A Closer Look at Leadership Theories

Every company, no matter what industry they’re a part of or how big they are, needs good leadership to be successful. Good leaders are a vital part of effective business practices. And for most, being a good leader doesn’t come inherently. That’s why there are entire [degree programs dedicated to management](#) and helping students become great leaders in their business.

In the world of leadership there are many theories about how leadership works, what makes good leaders, and how to be effective. There are many [leadership styles](#) that managers can employ and their impact varies based on the group they are leading and the industry they are in. These leadership theories explain how leadership styles work within a company to bring success. If you are studying to become a [business leader or manager](#), it’s important to understand these different leadership theories and how they impact your leadership and management style.

What is a leadership theory?

Leadership theories are the explanations of how and why certain people become leaders. They focus on the traits and behaviors that people can adopt to increase their leadership capabilities. [Some of the top traits that leaders say are vital to good leadership include:](#)

- Strong ethics and high moral standards
- Great self-organizational skills
- Efficient learner
- Nurtures growth in employees
- Fosters connection and belonging

Research shows that these traits are considered the most important to leaders around the world. And leadership theories help explain how leaders harness and develop these traits. Recently leadership theories have been more formalized, making them easier to understand, discuss, and analyze in action.

Ralph Nader says “The function of leadership is to produce more leaders, not followers.” This is considered transformational leadership—a leader can alter the perspective or psychology of a follower and shift them to want to become a leader too. This suggests that at the end of the day, leadership should be elevating and inspiring. Leaders should push the people they lead to new heights, helping them to grow into what they know they can become. Transformational leadership is an important psychological perspective for leaders to study and understand if they want to really influence and impact others. Different leadership theories address to create stronger and more effective leadership, helping followers become encouraged to be leaders themselves.

Major leadership theories.

While there are dozens of leadership theories and psychology, there are a few that are more well-known. These more common leadership theories are important to understand and recognize, especially if you currently are, or are [studying](#) to be business leader in the future. Understanding psychological and social impacts of effective leadership will help you determine the kind of leader you want to be.

--**Behavioral theory.** The behavioral leadership theory focuses on how leaders behave, and assumes that these traits can be copied by other leaders. Sometimes called the style theory, it suggests that leaders aren't born successful, but can be created based on learnable behavior. Behavioral theories of leadership focus heavily on the actions of a leader—this theory suggests that the best predictor of leadership success is viewing how a leader acts. Action rather than qualities are the focal points of behavioral learning theory. Patterns of behavior are observed and categorized as “styles of leadership” in this theory. Some of the styles of leadership include task-oriented leaders, people-oriented leaders, country club leaders, status-quo leaders, dictatorial leaders, and more. At the end of the day, the actions and actual behaviors of a leader are what defines success in this theory.

The behavioral theory has many advantages, primarily that leaders can learn and decide what actions they want to implement to become the kind of leader they want to be. It allows leaders to be flexible and adapt based on their circumstances. Another great benefit of this leadership style is that it suggests anyone is capable of becoming a leader. Some disadvantages of the behavioral theory are that while it allows flexibility, it doesn't directly suggest how to behave in certain circumstances. There are dozens of leadership styles that stem from the behavioral theory, but there isn't a right one for every circumstance.

A great example of the behavioral theory is looking at a task-oriented leader vs. a people-oriented leader. If there's a problem with a team, a task-oriented leader will look at the process to see if something needs to be adjusted with the workflow. A people-oriented leader will look at the individuals and go right to them, asking what the issue is. Whatever behaviors you choose, the behavioral leadership theory helps leaders focus on their actions and utilize their decisions to be a great leader.

--**Contingency theory.** The contingency leadership theory, sometimes called situational theory, focuses on the context of a leader. These theories look at the situational effects of the success or failure of a leader. A leader's effectiveness is directly determined by the situational context. While a leader's personality is a small factor in their success, the most important factor is the context and situation of the leader. This theory takes the specific leadership styles and suggests that good leaders can adjust their leadership style situationally. It also suggests that it may be best to find the right kind of leader for a specific situation. Types of contingency theories include the Hershey and Blanchard's Situational Theory, the Evans and House Path-Goal Theory, and Fiedler's Contingency Theory.

The contingency theory has great advantages, including that leaders are able to be effective no matter their situational context. However, this theory does have criticism suggesting that there isn't enough detail that goes into the context of any situation. Contingency theory focuses on the importance of a situation, but may not focus enough on the psychology of the employees or the company itself. It also may not focus enough on how leadership styles can change over time.

There are internal and external factors that impact a leader and their situation. The type of company, the size of the team, and the innate leadership style of an individual are internal factors. External factors may

include the customer feelings and the marketplace. All of these situations play a factor into the contingency theory.

--**Great Man theory.** The great man theory of leadership, sometimes called the trait theory, suggests that good leaders are born. They have innate traits and skills that make them great, and these are things that can't be taught or learned. The trait theory suggests that leaders deserve to be in their position because of their special traits.

There is a great amount of criticism for the trait theory, mainly that leaders are either born or not, that there isn't work or effort that is needed to be put in so you can become a leader. This suggests that social or psychological leaders are predetermined and that leaders are unable to come from the shadows—they are either chosen or not. There is also criticism that most of the traits associated with this theory are inherently masculine, and don't match the real psychology of good leaders.

People cite Abraham Lincoln, Alexander the Great, Queen Elizabeth I, and many others as their examples of the great man theory. These social giants utilized their skills to lead nations. High levels of ambition and determination are usually seen in leaders that appear to bring this theory to life. Today, leaders that climb to the top may view their traits and abilities as part of the "great man" theory. So it may appear that leaders get to their position based on their inherit gifts.

--**Management theory.** The management theory is sometimes called transactional leadership, and focuses on supervision, organization, and group performance. Transactional leadership is a system of rewards and punishments, and transactional leadership is regularly used in business. When employees do something successful, managers reward them. When they fail, they may get punished. Transactional rewards and punishments are given based on the idea that people really only do things for the reward. Their psychology doesn't allow human beings to do things out of goodness, but rather out of the promise of a reward.

The management leadership style can be extremely effective. Positive reinforcement is known for working wonders with employees, encouraging and motivating them to succeed. But there is lots of criticism around leadership that is strictly transactional as well. Consequences and punishments can decrease morale in an organization, negatively impacting employees. It can also be seen as a lazy leadership style—rewards and punishments are a relatively simple way to lead employees.

A common example of this management style is a leader that offers a cash bonus for employees who meet a goal. Or a leader who makes employees do extra paperwork if they miss a deadline.

--**Participative theory.** Participative leadership isn't as common in the corporate world. Sometimes called democratic leadership, this leadership theory suggests that employees be directly involved in decision making in their organization. The leader simply facilitates a conversation and then takes all the suggestions, and comes up with the best possible action. In this theory, everyone is very involved with decisions for the team and organization, with the leader simply helping direct the charge.

There are many advantages to this theory. Employees feel more engaged and motivated when they are directly involved in decisions and outcomes for their company. This theory is not without criticism however—some suggest that this type of style makes leaders appear weak or unnecessary. It is also a criticism that leaders in this theory don't actually get the best outcomes, because they are too engaged in what people want more than what the company needs.

Bill Gates is a well known example of participative theory. While this theory is still hotly debated, there are many examples of companies that work to incorporate employees more in the decision making process. In this theory, a leader may have a meeting to ask employees how to solve a particular problem. They encourage employees to be open and honest about their thoughts. They take all the suggestions, and meet with other leaders to discuss them. Leaders then make a decision based on the input from employees and their own decision making. Employees tend to appreciate this style, though it can be less effective overall.

--**Power theory.** This theory looks at the way a leader utilizes their power and influence to get things accomplished. French and Raven's Five Forms of Power is a commonly known power theory of leadership. It looks at positional power and personal power and how they impact leaders choices and outcomes.

This theory may appear to be highly effective—leaders with great power may seem highly efficient and get things done quickly. However, most employees don't appreciate power leadership. They want a leader who doesn't wield power over them, but works with them and encourages them. Thus the greatest criticism of this theory is that it doesn't reach the end goal of inspiring and encouraging employees, but rather makes them feel dominated.

The power theory can be seen in organizations where hierarchy and promotion is key to success. Employees in power theory companies see that their only way to influence change or impact the company is to gain power of their own. This can result in low morale, political, and cliquey climates in the office.

--**Relationship theory.** The relationship theory of leadership focuses on leaders who are mainly concerned about their interactions with others. They are often mentors for employees, scheduling time to talk to them and working to meet their needs. These kinds of leaders are focused on making work enjoyable for as many people as possible, and they want to foster a positive work environment. Studies show that this kind of leadership behavior can be the most effective for many employees. Relationship-oriented managers often get better results from their employees.

There are many advantages to this kind of leadership. Employees feel confident in their leader and want to follow them. They are also inspired to be good leaders to others. Mentorship provides great opportunities to foster growth in employees, and encourages them to stay at the organization for a longer period of time. There are some critics for this kind of leadership however, including thoughts that relationship driven leaders may be unwilling to view employees who are causing problems at face value, they can let relationships get in the way of work, and they can be guided to favor people over productivity. However, most experts agree that relationship driven leaders are actually more effective at the end of the day.

An example of relationship theory would be a manager who takes a newer employee under her wing. She works to help this employee understand how they fit within the organization, encourage them to be open about questions and problems, and create a positive working relationship. This employee then is encouraged to work hard, point out issues, and help solve problems for the company.

If you're an aspiring business leader attending school, it's important to understand leadership theories and how they impact you and your leadership style. Recognizing what leadership style you gravitate toward, or what leadership theory you'd like to employ, can help you determine how to be the most effective

leader possible. It's valuable to recognize leadership theories and styles in the company you work for, and understand what you can do to carry on that leadership theory or improve on it.

